

CLICKBAIT BIAS AND PROPAGANDA IN INFORMATION NETWORKS



Fister et al.

Clickbait Bias and Propaganda in Information Networks

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Licensing

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1: Chapter 1

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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2.1: Keywords

This chapter defines words and phrases that pertain to networked information. As the course progresses, we might add to this list.

ADTECH – advertising technology that directs advertising to individuals through systems such as behind-the-scenes auctions and the use of data to tailor ads to individual histories and susceptibilities and to analyze the results of advertising (also called “tailored advertising” or “targeted advertising”; if highly personalized it might be called “microtargeted advertising”). One common practice used in digital advertising is A/B testing in which people are shown two different messages to determine which is more successful and to tailor messaging to specific populations. Adtech is not just used to sell consumer goods; it’s also influential in political campaigns and, unlike in print or broadcast political advertising, disclosures about who paid for the ad are not required.

ALGORITHM – the set of logical rules used to organize and act on a body of data to solve a problem or to accomplish a goal, usually carried out by a machine. Typically, an algorithm is modeled, trained on a body of data, and then adjusted as the results are examined. Because algorithms are generally processed by computers and follow logical instructions, people often think of them as neutral or value-free, but the decisions made by humans as they design and tweak an algorithm and the data on which an algorithm is trained on can introduce human biases that can be compounded at scale. Humans who interact with an algorithm may also find ways to influence the outcomes, as when a marketer finds ways to push a website up in the results of a search.

ATTENTION ECONOMY – contemporary technology platforms benefit when people use them both to place ads in front of potential consumers and to increase their acquisition of personal data. Since our attention is a limited resource, companies (both platforms and people who use the platforms to sell, entertain, or persuade) try to engage and keep people’s attention. This rewards clickbait and influences the design of algorithms and platforms to maximize time spent online.

BIAS – Everyone has a limited perspective and, to that extent, every human utterance is subject to bias, but the word is generally used to mean an unfair and disproportionate preference for one side against another. For example, a journalist may make every effort to avoid having their reporting influenced by personal beliefs, but still must decide how to frame a story, including what examples to provide and who to consult as sources. A scholar will take steps to avoid personal beliefs from influencing their research, but will always struggle with the impossibility of total objectivity. When thinking about bias, it’s important to distinguish between deliberate and unfair weighting of a perspective from the inescapable limits of a person’s position.

BULLSHIT – communication without regard to truthfulness. Claims are invented or adopted to suit a purpose and the speaker doesn’t care whether they are true or false. Unlike a lie, which is a deliberate falsehood, bullshit is created without any particular truth or falsity in mind; it’s invention that purports to be true without any concern about truth itself and without employing or respecting methods used to distinguish truth from falsity. The concept overlaps at times with clickbait (statements are invented for profit) and propaganda (statements are invented for a political purpose) and, of course, can be both profitable and political. See Harry Frankfurt’s [On Bullshit](#) for a philosophical treatment of the concept.

CLICKBAIT – headlines or teasers for stories that are designed to encourage clicking through to view the digital content by using scandalous, sensational, exaggerated, gross-out, or misleading information. Because success of advertising and of digital platforms is measured by click-through rate, there is an incentive to create clickbait both among new media sites and traditional journalism. Some platforms have begun to minimize those incentives. For example, in 2014 Facebook announced it would automatically demote content if those who clicked through left a site quickly because the headline didn’t live up to its promise. Whether that has actually been accomplished is unclear.

DATA VOID – a word or phrase that can be manipulated in search results for ideological purposes. When something new enters the culture, pages can be quickly created to fill a void by providing information geared to the interests of a particular viewpoint. Manipulators may also introduce new names for concepts that will surface propaganda in a search or take advantage of problematic expressions to provide their preferred definitions when others aren’t available. Any void in search results is ripe for manipulation by filling it with misinformation or propaganda..

DISINFORMATION – the deliberate communication of false or misleading information for political purposes. The origin of the word is Russian and dates to the Stalin era when disinformation was used by intelligence organizations to foster state aims. It began to be included in dictionaries of the English language in the 1980s. While some disinformation is intended to convince people something false is true, the larger goal is to disillusion the populace by making it seem impossible to believe in the truth of anything.

FAKE NEWS – a phrase that in its early use described content that looked like news but was invented simply to attract clicks for profit. It evolved into a description of new media outlets that presented news stories that aligned with a political perspective while

being largely indifferent to traditional journalistic practices. The phrase flipped its meaning and became a synonym for traditional mainstream news organizations when President Trump began to call them “fake news,” essentially setting up a binary opposition between right-wing publications that supported Trump and mainstream and left-wing publications that either opposed Trump or reported news he didn’t like.

LISTICLE – a form of clickbait that uses lists, such as “Top Ten . . .” “100 most . . .” or “50 ways . . .”, a style particularly popular in the non-journalistic articles at [BuzzFeed](#).

MEME – small units of culture, often humorous, frequently visual in nature, that are spread through imitation and alteration. Though the term was coined in the pre-internet age, it now refers primarily to digital works that riff off a common image or idea. Memes may form within a specific community and require a kind of “insider” knowledge to decode or remix. They can spread quickly through social media, offering a multitude of variations on a theme. The origin and meaning of specific memes can be explored at [Know Your Meme](#).

MODERATION – the process of screening user-contributed content online. Every online platform that allows users to contribute, whether uploading videos to YouTube or making a comment on a news article, has to put rules in place to screen out illegal or offensive content as well as automated advertising messages (i.e. spam). Moderation usually involves a mix of algorithmic screening that uses machine learning to identify problematic material and human reviewing of material either before it is made public or after it is flagged. It also involves responding to harassment and trolling, developing rules and procedures for making decisions about suspending or banning users from a platform. For more information about these practices, see Sarah Jeong’s *The Internet of Garbage* and Tarleton Gillespie’s *Custodians of the Internet*.

PLATFORM – in computing, platform traditionally referred to a combination of hardware and operating system software, such as Windows for PCs or iOS for Macs; now it has extended to sites (such as Facebook) that provide proprietary software that runs on the internet and may allow third party developers to create new applications specific to that site.

PROPAGANDA – communications designed to influence a population so it will form beliefs and behave in ways that are consistent with the propagandist’s political and social objectives. Disinformation is a technique often employed for propagandistic purposes. In some definitions, propaganda is intentionally aimed at a specific audience with a political aim in mind, distinguishing it from commercial marketing, though both may use similar persuasion techniques and technologies. In the early 20th century propaganda was associated with the new field of public relations and was used extensively to recruit support for involvement in World War I, but the word began to have a negative connotation thereafter as anti-democratic and misleading. In their book *Manufacturing Consent*, Noam Chomsky and Edward S. Herman used the phrase “corporate propaganda” to mean efforts to protect corporate power against political or democratic intervention.

RED PILL – inspired by the film *The Matrix*, in which a character is offered a blue pill (which will allow them to live comfortably in a world that is an illusion) or a red pill (where they will experience the truth and therefore freedom), this phrase indicates a revelation that what people generally accept as true is completely false. It’s often used as a sort of meta-conspiracy theory that feminism, the mainstream media, the economic system, and the existence of racism are false narratives that are woven together to oppress the gullible masses and those who are “red-pilled” have broken free. It’s generally a term adopted by the far right, particularly white men on the far right, except when used to describe those who claim to have taken the red pill. In the context of this course, it’s significant in that no amount of fact-checking or argument can persuade a person who believes “common reality” is a delusion, or rather that their reality is the only true reality and most people have been seduced by an illusion.

SJW – acronym for “social justice warrior,” a term of opprobrium for feminists and those who express concern about social justice, particularly if it threatens aspects of culture that were traditionally male and white such as comics, science fiction, or gaming. The term became popularized during “gamergate” in which angry gamers conducted a harassment campaign against woman who created or wrote about games with progressive themes. Those who use the term claim those who express progressive views in these cultural arenas do so only for self-aggrandizement to discount the validity of their views.

SURVEILLANCE CAPITALISM – a concept developed by Shoshana Zuboff (most thoroughly in her book *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*) meaning the monetization of massive amounts of personally-identifiable data in order to predict and influence human behavior for profit. Zuboff considers the development of surveillance systems that constantly capture intimate details of human life at a global scale an “expropriation of critical human rights that is best understood as a coup from above” and “an overthrow of the people’s sovereignty” because this process appropriates human experience as free raw material for building proprietary systems of prediction and control. Initially seen as a way of selling targeted advertising, this form of capitalism is now being built into phones that we carry everywhere with us, cars, home appliances, smart homes, even smart cities with the data used

for more than advertising – for example, to allocate benefits, determine sentences, or to train machines to replace human labor. As Zuboff put it in an [interview](#), “Once we searched Google, but now Google searches us. Once we thought of digital services as free, but now surveillance capitalists think of us as free.”

TROLL – a person, often operating in groups, who deliberately upset targets by sending them unsettling or offensive material, often in an attempt to damage their reputation or drive them from a platform. Originally trolling was purposeless other than “for the lulz” – a warped sense of humorous mischief. More recently the term describes anyone who engages in offensive or destructive attacks online. Used as a verb it often means coordinated and frequent attacks in disputes about social, cultural, or political issues or the practice of using various strategies to derail or disrupt a discussion. Trolls employ a winning strategy because they tend to either attract shocked attention (a win) or to force those they attack to leave the argument or platform (also a win). For a full ethnographic analysis, see [This is Why We Can't Have Nice Things](#) by Whitney Phillips.

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2.2: Four Moves . . .

“Abandoning facts means abandoning freedom.” Timothy Synder, *On Tyranny*.

Being able to prove or disprove factual information is not the only way we can assess information or evaluate an argument, but facts are a key building-block of knowledge. Given the volume of factual claims we encounter every day in social media, in news stories, in political speeches, in arguments with That Opinionated Uncle, it may seem impossible to tackle the problem. Who has the time?

What people need most when confronted with a claim that appears to be factual but may not be 100 percent true is simple strategies to get closer to the truth. It doesn’t have to take a lot of time and work to take one or two key fact-claims and check them for accuracy.

These four moves (or tactics) can get you started with the fact-checking process. Try them in order.

- **Check for previous work:** Look around to see if someone else has already fact-checked the claim or provided a synthesis of research on the claim. Fact-checking sites are good sources for this move, particularly if the fact you’re checking has been getting a lot of attention. When you encounter a claim you want to check, your first move might be to see if sites like [Politifact](#), [Snopes](#), or even [Wikipedia](#) have researched the claim.
- **Go upstream:** Most web content is not original. Get to the original source to understand the trustworthiness of the information. This may be the first newspaper article that reported the claim; it may be a published journal article reporting original research or a government document. If the claim is about a research finding, try to find the original article. If the claim is about an event, try to find the original reporting.
- **Read laterally:** (This useful phrase was popularized by Sam Wineburg and his colleagues at the Stanford History Education Group.) Once you get to the source of a claim, make a quick check to see what other people think about the source (the publication, the author, etc.). Maybe you get lucky and the source is something you already know is reputable, such as the journal [Science](#) or the newspaper [The New York Times](#). If so, you can stop there. If not, dig around to see what you can find out about the source. Increasingly Wikipedia includes articles about publications with basic background about them. You can also make a quick check to see how others have addressed the same topic. Is this claim widely believed? Embraced by a particular group? Or is it contradicted by most sources? The truth is in the network.
- **Circle back:** If you get lost, hit dead ends, or find yourself going down an increasingly confusing rabbit hole, back up and start over knowing what you know now. You’ve learned something about the claim. Now you’re likely to take a more informed path with different search terms and better decisions. And if at any point you fail—if the source you find is not trustworthy, complex questions emerge, or the claim turns out to have multiple sub-claims—then circle back to step one, pick another fact-claim, and start over.

In general, try these moves in sequence. If you find success at any stage, your work might be done.

But How Do I Know What Sources are “Reputable”?

This is a fraught question today. A sizeable percentage of Americans distrust all “mainstream media.” A recently published book, [Network Propaganda: Manipulation, Disinformation, and Radicalization in American Politics](#) by Yochai Benkler, Robert Faris, and Hal Roberts (Oxford, 2018) conducted extensive network analysis of news consumption and social sharing. They concluded our news media have bifurcated. There’s an entire self-referential media ecosystem centered on Fox News and embracing many right-wing and far-right websites that amplify and affirm one another while discrediting all news sources that fall outside their circle as “biased,” “left-wing,” or even “fake.” This is what the authors of the book call a “propaganda feedback loop.” In this media sphere, adherence to a partisan belief system and cultural identity is more important than being factually correct. A claim that is demonstrably false is more acceptable than stating something that challenges the overarching political narrative.

Doesn’t this happen on the left-wing too? There are hyperpartisan sites on the left that traffic in rumors and lies, but the difference is their audiences tend to balance their consumption of those sites with mainstream news organizations that generally attempt to adhere to journalistic norms set out in the Society of Professional Journalists [Code of Ethics](#). In this sphere, it’s harder to maintain a story or a position based on “facts” that can be disproved or that even seem unlikely. Traditional journalistic processes are valued as much as or more than alignment with a set of political beliefs, and fewer people on the left dismiss the mainstream media’s reporting out of hand.

In this course, healthy skepticism is encouraged, but blanket distrust of mainstream news organizations based only on alleged political bias is not supportable. Part of the job of becoming a savvy information consumer is figuring out what sources of

information you can, for the most part, trust to get it right much of the time and strive to correct mistakes.

Some generally-respected news organizations include . . .

- [*The New York Times*](#)
- [*The Wall Street Journal*](#)
- [*The Los Angeles Times*](#)
- [*The Washington Post*](#)
- [*PBS NewsHour*](#)
- [*NPR*](#)
- [*BBC*](#)

Sorting News from Opinion

These news organizations publish both news reporting and opinion pieces. Opinion pieces will be deliberately persuasive and often provocative. News reporting strives to be more objective. However, in both cases the publishers strive to avoid promoting obvious falsehoods, though they will accept opinion pieces that readers (and their own editorial board) may vehemently disagree with. When you look at an article, pay attention to who wrote it and why. For more on sorting news from opinion, see [Chapter 6](#).

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2.3: . . . and a Habit- Check Your Emotions

In addition to the moves, there's a habit to cultivate: *Check your emotions*.

When you feel strong emotion – happiness, anger, pride, vindication – and that emotion pushes you to assume something is true and share a “fact” with others, stop and think. These are *exactly* the claims that you must fact-check.

Why? Because you're already predisposed to analyze things that put you an intellectual frame of mind. But things that make you angry or overjoyed, well... our record as humans is not good when it comes to being influenced by our emotions.

Our normal inclination is to agree with content that we already feel is correct. (Psychologists call this “confirmation bias.” We are inclined to accept things that align with what we already believe and reject or ignore things that don't.) Moreover, researchers have found that content that causes strong emotions (both positive and negative) spreads the fastest through our social networks. This shouldn't surprise us; social media platforms are designed to maximize “stickiness.” They do everything they can to keep users engaged, because engagement is profitable. Savvy activists, advocates, and marketers take advantage of platform design and human psychology, getting past our filters by posting material that goes straight to our hearts.

Not only that, but whoever writes a headline is likely trying to catch your attention, and that can distort the meaning of a story. “Clickbait” is designed to provoke an emotion so it can spread. Resist the urge to share something based only on a headline. If you read the story – even if you simply skim it quickly – you will have a better sense of what it's really about and whether it's something you want to share. (Incidentally, authors of news stories usually don't write their own headlines, so don't blame them if they are ridiculously off base.)

Use your emotions as a checkpoint. Strong emotions should become a trigger for your new fact-checking habit. Every time content you want to share makes you feel rage, laughter, ridicule, or even a heartwarming buzz, spend 30 seconds fact-checking. You might avoid misleading others and embarrassing yourself by passing along something that's simply not true.

In some cases an emotionally-charged piece of news may be factually true, but more complicated than it appears at first. By learning the context and the complexities through a more nuanced source of information, you can share valuable information without all the emotional baggage. You might even help cool down an over-heated argument.

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2.4: Finding Already-Checked Facts

When you see a factual claim circulating on the internet that you want to check, someone may have already done the work for you. Particularly in the realm of current political news, there are a number of organizations that routinely examine claims made by public figures. Viral content online, too, is often fact-checked. Here are some prominent fact-checking sites:

- [PolitiFact](#)
- [Factcheck.org](#)
- [Washington Post Fact Checker](#)
- [Snopes](#)
- [Truth be Told](#)
- [NPR Fact-Check](#)
- [Detector de Mentiras](#) (Univision, Spanish language)
- [Guardian Reality Check](#) (UK)
- [BBC Reality Check](#) (UK)

Rather than prowl through these sites one by one, there's a nifty search trick you can use. Pull together key words, phrases, or concepts from the claim you want to check and put them into a search bar, adding **site:** and the url of a fact-check site. Better yet, try two sites and compare them. For example, search:

George Soros paid caravan site:snopes.com

or **George Soros paid caravan site:politifact.com**

Because these fact-checking sites tend to focus on current political news, they have limited use when fact-checking something that isn't headline news or a notorious viral hoax. The next chapter will offer more tricks and tips for strategically learning about a site.

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2.5: Handy Tricks for Fact-Checkers

In addition to the four moves and a habit, these shortcuts will help you evaluate sources and check facts efficiently.

Quickly grab key phrases: highlight the text, right click, and select a search engine. If the information you're examining is time-sensitive, click on "news" to get the latest.

Search for a source by name but exclude the source itself from a search: by adding to a search a minus sign and URL, you can search for sites that mention the source. For example:

daily caller -site:<https://dailycaller.com/>

youtube algorithm extremism -site:<https://youtube.com>

(However, this will include any social media sites maintained by the site, such as Facebook or Twitter.)

Find out when a site was registered – and possibly who is behind it: go to <https://whois.com> and paste in a URL (the part up to the first /). Every time a website is created, the creator has to provide contact and technical information to a central registry. Sometimes the information is detailed; quite often, though, a registrar will hide the details under a proxy. In that case, the only useful information you will find is the date it was registered and when it is up for renewal. There are several sites where you can run whois searches. This one works well if you ignore their advertising for domain registration and internet hosting.

Track down an image using a reverse-image search: Go to <https://images.google.com> and either paste in the image URL or upload a copy of the image. This won't necessarily lead you to the original; you'll likely find multiple copies of a viral image. Scan through the links to see what source seems most likely to include useful information. You might also find it useful, if looking for an older image, to use the "tools" option to limit by date. [TinEye](#) is another reverse image search if you want an alternative to Google.

Find the original source using a date limiter: In a Google search, clicking under Tools and Anytime will give you a chance to limit a search by date. Using the custom date range option, start some time ago – say up until 2009 – and, if that fails to locate the source, reset your date limiter adding a year or two.

Find the original source using place as a clue: Sometimes a site will relate news without telling you who originally reported it. Try searching for a news source from the place where the item reported in the news happened by searching the city and "newspaper" or "local affiliate" for television news. Then search on the site of a local news outlet to see how it was first reported locally. Chances are the story got a little garbled in the retelling.

Find a previous version by using the Wayback Machine: Sometimes you may want to see how a page has changed over time. The [Internet Archive has saved billions of websites](#) over the years, so you can type in an address and see how a site looked in the past. Some pages or parts of pages may be missing and whether a page is archived will often depend on if a page was heavily linked to in the past, or if the site owner wanted it excluded from the archive.

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2.6: What If I'm Not Sure About a Source's Reliability?

Authority and reliability are tricky to evaluate. Whether we admit it or not, most of us would like to ascribe authority to sites and authors who seem to support our viewpoints and approach publications that disagree with our worldview with skepticism.

How do we escape our own prejudices? Try applying [Wikipedia's guidelines](#) for determining the reliability of publications. These guidelines were developed to help people with diametrically opposed positions argue in dispassionate ways about the reliability of sources using common criteria. For Wikipedians, reliable sources are defined by *process*, *expertise*, and *aim*.

Process

Above all, a reliable source for facts should have a process in place for encouraging accuracy, verifying facts, and correcting mistakes. Note that reputation and process might be apart from issues of bias. The editorial pages of the *New York Times* have a center-left bias, while those of the *Wall Street Journal* a center-right bias. The stories they choose to cover are also influenced by editors deciding what is important for their readership and role. Yet fact-checkers of all political stripes are happy to be able to track a fact down to one of these publications since they have reputations for a high degree of accuracy and issue corrections when they get facts wrong.

The same thing applies to peer-reviewed publications. While there is much debate about the inherent flaws of peer review, peer review does mean there are many eyes on data and results. This process helps to keep many obviously flawed results out of publication. If a peer-reviewed journal has a large following of experts, that provides even more eyes on the article, and more chances to spot flaws. Since one's reputation for research is on the line in front of one's peers, it also provides incentives to be precise in claims and careful in analysis in a way that other forms of communication might not.

Expertise

According to Wikipedians, researchers and certain classes of professionals have expertise, and their usefulness is defined by that expertise. For example, we would expect a marine biologist to have a more informed opinion about the impact of global warming on marine life than the average person, particularly if the biologist has done research in that area. Professional knowledge matters too: we'd expect a health inspector to have a reasonably good knowledge of health code violations, even if they are not a published scholar of the area. And while we often think researchers are more knowledgeable than professionals, this is not always the case. For a range of issues, professionals in a given area might have more nuanced and up-to-date insight than many researchers, especially where question deal with common practice.

Reporters, on the other hand, often have no domain expertise, but may strive to accurately summarize and convey the views of experts, professionals, and event participants. Reporters who write in a niche area (their "beat") over many years (e.g. science or education policy) may acquire expertise themselves. Nevertheless, they will seek out experts for information when working on a story.

Aim

Aim is defined by what the publication, author, or media source is attempting to accomplish. Aims are complex. Respected scientific journals, for example, aim for prestige within the scientific community by publishing important new research, but must also have a business model to fund their publishing operation. *The New York Times* relies on subscriptions and ad revenue but is also dependent on maintaining a reputation for accuracy and even-handedness, so it maintains an organizational separation between the staff whose job is to bring in money and the editors and journalists whose job is to report news.

One way to think about aim is to ask what incentives an article or author has to get things right. An opinion column that gets a fact or two wrong won't cause its author much trouble, whereas an article in a newspaper that gets facts wrong may damage the reputation of the reporter. On the far ends of the spectrum, a single bad or retracted article by a scientist can ruin a career, whereas an advocacy blog site or a YouTube celebrity can twist facts daily with few consequences.

Policy think tanks, such as the Cato Institute and the Center for American Progress, are interesting hybrid cases. To maintain their funding, they must continue to promote aims that have a particular bias. At the same time, their prestige depends on them promoting these aims (and being clear about their mission) while maintaining some level of factual integrity.

Bottom line: look for publications that have strong incentives to get things right, as shown by both authorial intent and business model, reputational incentives, and mission.

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2.7: Sorting News From Opinion

Traditional news organizations publish different kinds of articles in sections that have different expectations for writers and different editors selecting and shaping articles. Newsroom staff gather and report news (and newsrooms also publish stories by “stringers” or freelance journalists who are not on staff but are real, live journalists committed to the same values and practices as staffers). Some newsroom journalists don’t focus on “hard news” – they write features about style or business or the arts or sports. They also may publish analysis or in-depth investigative articles about things that aren’t breaking news of the day but help readers understand the complexities of newsworthy issues. A reporter may spend months looking into why kids in a particular neighborhood have high rates of asthma. Another may analyze why voters found a particular candidate appealing or why a policy decision in the US Congress is being held up. Those articles are not straight news reporting, but they aren’t opinion, either. Sources are provided, facts are checked. In fact, this example of fact-checking an investigative piece shows just how much work is involved to get the story right.

The new findings on commercial and industrial valuations expose many of the same flaws, with the assessor’s office generally undervaluing downtown skyscrapers and boutiques while overvaluing small businesses in poorer neighborhoods. *4.4 1.5*

In 2015, for instance, a building on Oak Street in the Gold Coast neighborhood sold for \$47 million. Yet the assessor set the property’s value that year at \$2.6 million — only 5.5 percent of the sale price. *4.4 → 6.6 — 12.8*

Eight miles west, a small industrial shop in the working-class Belmont Central neighborhood sold for \$110,000 in 2015. The assessor’s estimate that year was \$207,140, nearly twice as much as the sale price. *3.3 1.5*

The effects of flawed commercial and industrial valuations aren’t limited to people who own businesses. Owners of residential properties, as a group, also ended up paying more in property taxes than they would have if the assessor’s office had done its work properly. *5.2 1.5*

The total amount of property taxes collected in a given year is fixed, so if one group of property owners doesn’t pay its fair share others have to make up the difference. And for years, the county has significantly undervalued commercial and industrial properties as a class, according to the ProPublica Illinois-Chicago Tribune analysis as well as studies conducted by the Illinois Department of Revenue. That means the estimated total value of those properties, after appeals, was less than it should have been. *2.2 ON AVERAGE*

The extra burden on homeowners was even greater for people who owned lower-priced properties, since the assessor already tended to overvalue them in comparison with other homes. *6.2 1.5*

The assessor’s office encourages property owners to file an appeal if they are dissatisfied with an assessment. In cases where Berrios did not change a property’s initial estimate from one reassessment to the next, the vast majority of the owners did so, government records show. *89.8%*

Seventy-four percent of those owners won reductions from the assessor — only to see the values snap right back to the same number in the next reassessment. *6.2 1.5*

“There is no rationale for having no change in these initial valuations,” said Richard Almy, former executive director of the International Association of Assessing Officers. “Especially if the assessor later agreed to a reduction, there’s no earthly reason for them to go back to the same value.” *Indecent Ass.*

Source: Louise Kiernan, “Calculating the Work Behind Our Work,” *ProPublica Illinois*, December 29, 2017.

News stories usually don’t get as extensive a treatment; there’s just not enough time to retrace every step before the story goes out. However, editors will look for weaknesses and demand key facts be checked if they seem wobbly. There should be confirmation of any factual claim a source has made. Nothing should be taken at face value. There’s an old saying among journalists: if your mother says she loves you, check it out.

Opinion pieces and editorials (op/ed for short) are different. An editorial, strictly speaking, expresses the opinion of an editorial board. The board of the *Wall Street Journal* may write an article stating “we should do this” but their reporters would get in trouble if they tried to sneak that opinion into their reporting. An opinion piece is written by someone who presumably has both expertise and a point they want to make.

Opinion pieces make arguments. They recommend or persuade or simply make people think in a different way. Some opinion pieces are written by writers who are hired to share their thoughts on a regular basis – columnists like Tom Friedman or Michelle Alexander who write for *The New York Times*. Others are written by guests to the publication. A good news organization will not publish an argument that relies on lies or has no evidence for claims, but they go out of their way to publish arguments that their editorial board disagrees with so readers will encounter a range of approaches to ideas.

That’s how traditional news organizations make distinctions. There are also mixed sources such as *The New Yorker* which publishes different types of content, including fiction, reviews, essays, and satire, as well as thoroughly-sourced news stories and analysis. New media publications that have a less formal presentation – *Quartz*, *Vice*, *Buzzfeed* and the like – blur these distinctions more than traditional news organizations do. It’s harder to tell what’s news and what’s opinion, though sometimes these upstarts break a major news story. Likewise, on cable news it can be hard to distinguish a statement by a talk show host or an assertion by a pundit brought in for commentary from a statement made by a reporter. But they are distinctions that matter. Ask yourself: Who said that? What job were they doing when they said it?

When thinking about the information we get through networks, it’s worthwhile thinking about what kind of information it is. Is it news reporting? Is it opinion? Is it an advertisement dressed up to fool you into thinking it’s news? Is it disinformation camouflaged as news? Always take a moment to know what type of information you’re dealing with before you run with it.

When in doubt about a particular news source, see if Wikipedia has an article about it that describes its focus and reputation. If you want to see behind the scenes, click on the Talk tab to see if Wikipedians have argued about how to describe that source.

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2.8: Stupid News Tricks

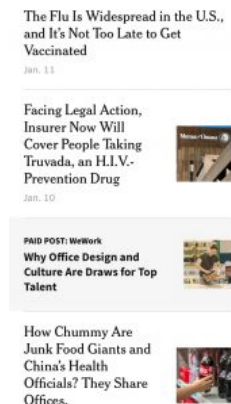
Okay, this chapter heading is an example of clickbait: it's a misleading headline. In reality, this chapter is about things reputable newspapers and other news sources routinely do in the course of business that you should be aware of as a critical news consumer.

Native Advertising

When you're looking at an article on a reputable site, you might see content like this example from *Inside Higher Ed*:



Note the boxed news item. It has a label – “content sponsored and provided by Ellucian.” It looks like a news story, but it’s advertising. Here’s an example from *The New York Times*.



Here it's labeled PAID POST – but if you weren't paying attention, you might think it's a news story because the layout is identical to the surrounding news stories.



This example from BoingBoing makes advertising harder to identify. All of the links under “Interesting for You” are ads placed by a company that is only indicated by a logo that is barely visible. (Incidentally, this example illustrates another thing to bear in mind.

BoingBoing mostly aggregates and summarizes news from other sources. In this case it's a summary of a story published in *The Intercept*. You would want to "go upstream" to *The Intercept* before took BoingBoing's word for it.)

Syndication

The previous example is from a site that mostly digests stories found elsewhere. Another way news sources incorporate news from other sources is syndication. Material from one site is published on another site (or in a print newspaper). Two prominent news agencies that aren't publications themselves but report news to be picked up by others are Reuters (headquartered in London) and The Associated Press or AP (headquartered in the New York). Another syndicated source you will frequently encounter is Agence France Press, the world's oldest news agency (headquartered in Paris). Additionally you might see in a local paper a story reprinted from *The New York Times* or *The Los Angeles Times* and many popular columnists are reprinted in multiple papers. Remember: it's worth going upstream and at least noting the original source. *The Mankato Free Press* will run articles about events in Washington D.C., but they don't have reporters working there. They syndicated that story from a news agency so Mankato residents will be informed.

In the following example, the source of this news story is not *The New York Times*, though it can be found on the *Times*' website.



If you have a beef with this article, it's not with reporting done by *The New York Times*. It's with journalists working for the Associated Press. You'll occasionally see people complaining about a story from *The New York Times*, claiming it is typically biased, only to find the story was not even written by *The New York Times*, but by the Associated Press, Reuters, or some other syndicator.

This can also cause confusion because AP stories stay on the *Times*' site for a limited period of time. If someone is outraged by a *Times* story and then — what!? — it *disappears*, they might conclude something nefarious happened. Was it retracted? Was it censored? What's going on?

There's a good chance the article that disappeared is a syndicated article. *Associated Press* articles, for example, are displayed on the site for a few weeks, then "roll off" and disappear from the site. Why? Because *The New York Times* only pays the Associated Press to show them on the site for a few weeks.

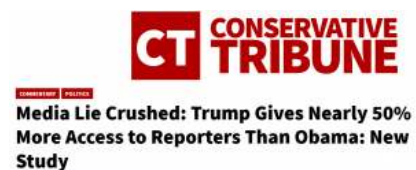
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2.9: When Going Upstream Is Hard Work

In the examples we've seen so far, going upstream is relatively easy. A reputable source includes information about its sources. Just as it's important for scholars to cite their sources, journalists need to tell their readers where their information comes from. Even when a source is not identified by name, it's typical practice to say why that person isn't named while also indicating why they are in a position to know something. For example, a story might quote an official who would be fired if his name was published or a police officer who was a witness to the event but was not an authorized press liaison. The *Times*, in the interest of transparency, has an [explanation](#) of their rules for these circumstances. Generally, though, sources are identified so readers can assess their credibility.

This is not just a journalistic standard, it's good internet citizenship. Articles on the web that repurpose other information or artifacts should state their sources, and, if possible, link to them. This matters to creators, because they deserve credit for their work. But it also matters to readers who need to check the credibility of the original sources. Unfortunately, many people on the web are not good citizens. This is particularly true with material that spreads quickly as hundreds or thousands of people share it – “viral” content.

When that information travels around a network, people often fail to link it to sources. For example, here is an interesting claim that President Trump is more accessible to the press than previous presidents, and that this fact contradicts a “media lie.”



[snip]

Research by Martha Kumar, director of the White House Transition Project, says that Trump has given a surprising amount of access to reporters.

"At his second year into his presidency, President Trump has given 200 interviews, 340 short question and answers sessions, 40 news conferences for a grand total of 580 interactions with the press. President Bill Clinton gave the most opportunities with 610," Sinclair Broadcast Group reported.

"When you look at all the public utterances (Trump) has: his speeches, remarks, his interviews, his press conferences and his short Q-and-A, you find over half are instances when he is taking questions from reporters," Kumar said.

In terms of question-and-answer sessions, Trump had 340 compared to Obama's 75.

The [article](#) links to a [news broadcast](#) as its source. That source quotes a researcher, Martha Kumar, and the organization she's affiliated with, but doesn't link directly to her research. The next step is to see if the original research is available at her organization's site. This turns up [a report on how presidents communicated with the press](#), comparing their preferences in the first hundred days of their first and second years. It turns out the claim of “50% more access” relates to specific kinds of press interactions.

Where the presidents differ is the venues they choose to meet with the press, including press conferences, interviews, and short question and answer sessions. President Trump, for example, routinely responds to a few questions every day or two while President Obama favored long form interviews where he could discuss policy. . . . [Trump focuses] on those forums and strategies that help him establish a narrative for the day – Tweet in the morning for the opening narrative and expand on it later in the day – and get others to talk about policy. In a sense, it is a loop that has him begin in early morning by tweeting and then build his narrative in answers to reporters' questions at the beginning or end of White House meetings with officials and outside guests, such as corporate executives. (executive summary and p. 4)

In other words, he has had more informal, unscripted interactions than other presidents, including tweets, but fewer formal opportunities for reporters to question white house officials.

The process of going upstream – checking out the source – will also establish that Sinclair Broadcasting Group is [known for its right-wing editorial stance](#). But this isn't entirely a right-wing issue; an opinion piece in the [Washington Post](#) described the report differently, but didn't link to the original, either.

Another factor to consider when going upstream by following sources is [research](#) conducted by Yochai Benkler, Robert Faris, and Hal Roberts that found close network relationships among a group of right-wing publications, including Fox News, talk radio, and

Breitbart. These outlets tend to draw on one another as sources, amplifying and confirming messages consistent with a partisan identity while also inducing distrust of media sources outside their circle. In contrast, consumers of left-wing partisan information sources also consume mainstream news sources that put a higher premium on performing objectivity and fact-checking, so the power of left-wing outlets to carry a strongly opinionated message is moderated by the more cautious mainstream.

Watch out for sources that primarily cite other sources that are within a particular partisan sphere. If, when you go upstream, all of the sources referred to fit within a partisan framework, take that into account.

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2.10: How Social Media Platforms Intersect With News

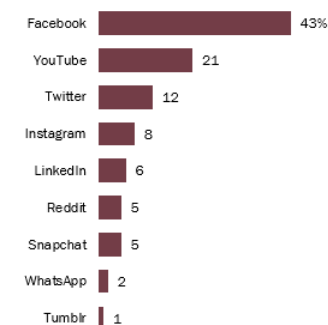
Take a moment to think about the last news item you read, heard, or watched. How did you encounter it? Were you looking for it or did it come looking for you? Were you visiting a news site online to see what's happening? Catch it on the radio while driving to work? Did you hear about it from a friend or teacher? Was it something that caught your eye when skimming a news app on your phone? Or while checking your favorite social media platform?

Information networks that don't create news are increasingly important discovery and distribution routes. Content created by news organizations spreads through social media when people share links and as the organizations promote their own content through Facebook, Snapchat, and elsewhere. This has benefits – news can reach people where they are and acquaintances can amplify the reach of a news story through a network of trust – but the downsides include organizations having to share dwindling ad revenue with the platforms and being at the whim of companies that can change their algorithms at any time without warning or consultation.

But social media is where news is at. A [survey](#) conducted by Pew Research in 2018 found two-thirds of American adults report getting news through social media, with Facebook and YouTube leading other platforms.

Social media sites as pathways to news

% of U.S. adults who get news on each social media site

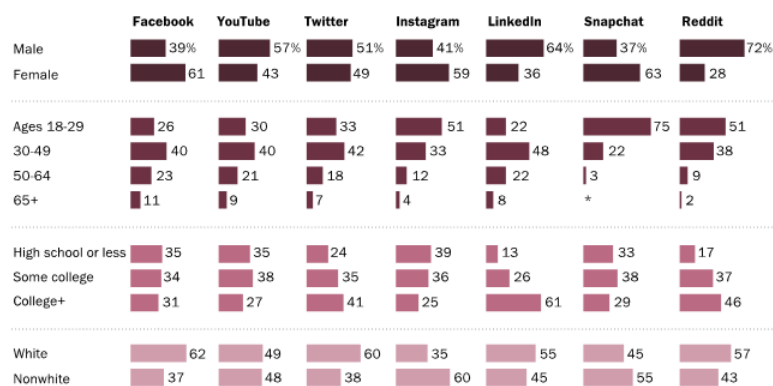


Source: Survey conducted July 30-Aug. 12, 2018.
"News Use Across Social Media Platforms 2018"

PEW RESEARCH CENTER

Profiles of social media news consumers

% of each social media site's news consumers who are ...



Note: Tumblr and WhatsApp not shown. Nonwhite includes all racial and ethnic groups, except non-Hispanic white.

Source: Survey conducted July 30-Aug. 12, 2018.

"News Use Across Social Media Platforms 2018"

PEW RESEARCH CENTER

Another [study](#) by Project Information Literacy involving nearly 6,000 college students at 11 institutions found nearly 90 percent of students got news through social media, second only to hearing about it from friends face-to-face or through online channels. A

large majority said journalism is necessary for democracy but most find it hard to keep up and half weren't confident they could identify whether a news story was fake or not. Over a third doubted the credibility of *all* news.

Alternative News, Alternative Facts

But it's not all about how journalism travels. Social platforms enable the creation of new information channels that challenge the dominance of traditional news organizations. That's not all bad. New players can provide valuable alternative viewpoints and cover news ignored by the mainstream, but it also enables the creation and spread of misinformation, disinformation, and propaganda. The incentives built into social networks promote the use of emotional appeals and reward "influencers" who engage large audiences by any means necessary. The more outrageous, the more they are richly rewarded. While reputations matter in these new information channels, they are not dependent on old-school journalistic values or practices. For example, a conspiracy theory about murders of South African farmers that circulated in white supremacist circles for years [broke into the mainstream](#) when a claim by a "citizen journalist" on YouTube was repeated by Tucker Carlson and then by the president in a Tweet.

Social platforms, meeting with new criticism, want to avoid taking responsibility for what appears on their platforms. While they will take material down if it violates their terms of use or is illegal (child pornography or copyright violations, for example), they rely on [a provision](#) of the Telecommunications Act of 1996 that immunizes internet providers.

No provider or user of an interactive computer service shall be treated as the publisher or speaker of any information provided by another information content provider.

Of course, this law predates the social platforms we use today and their meteoric rise to the top of the list of the world's most valuable corporations. Lawmakers in 1996 had no way of knowing billions of people would be using and contributing material through the internet, that we would be accessing volumes of information through our phones. They might have had reservations if they imagined a world where 300 hours of video would be uploaded to a single website every minute, that messages could rocket around the world instantly, that governments could be toppled or could undermine one another covertly through disinformation campaigns. Section 230 of the Act gave entrepreneurs the freedom to create new things. It also let them off the hook for the problems we're dealing with today. The consequences of this laissez-faire attitude are becoming more clear by the day, and platforms are scrambling to balance the ability of anyone to publish and share anything with the political and social fallout.

If you want to understand information, it's important to understand how information networks operate. Profiles of major social platforms will be presented in Part Three of this book.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Readings

3.1: Readings for IDS 101

3.2: Understanding Media and Information Quality in an Age of Artificial Intelligence, Automation, Algorithms and Machine Learning

3.3: Fake News and Fake Solutions- How Do We Build a Civics of Trust?

3.4: 3 Ways Facebook and Other Social Media Companies Could Clean Up Their Acts – If They Wanted To

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3.1: Readings for IDS 101

Students: Check the Team Drive for the most current schedule of readings, as they may change.

For those not enrolled in the course, but curious about what we decided to read together, here's the list.

[Teaching About Trump](#) (Wisconsin State Journal)

"What is Post-Truth?" in *Post-Truth* by Lee McIntyre (MIT, 2018)

[Nothing on This Page is Real](#) (Washington Post)

[Anti-Vaxxers, the Momo Challenge ... Why Lies Spread Faster Than Truth](#) (The Guardian)

Network Propaganda by Yochai Benkler, Robert Faris, and Hal Roberts, pp. 3-24

The Internet of Garbage by Sarah Jeong, pp. 12-39

"Google Has a Striking History of Bias Against Black Girls" by Safiya Noble (*Time* magazine)

[Surveillance Capitalism Has Gone Rogue](#) by Shoshana Zuboff (Washington Post)

Students also are asked to choose readings for us to discuss.

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3.2: Understanding Media and Information Quality in an Age of Artificial Intelligence, Automation, Algorithms and Machine Learning

By [Yochai Benkler](#), [Robert Faris](#), [Hal Roberts](#), and [Nikki Bourassa](#)

Reprinted from the [Berkman Klein Center](#) on [Medium](#), July 9, 2018. This article is licensed under a CC-BY-NC license.

This post looks at some of the lessons we've learned over the last year in our work as part of the Ethics and Governance of AI Initiative, a collaboration of the Berkman Klein Center and the MIT Media Lab. [Learn more](#).

Democracy is under stress that would have been unimaginable a decade or two ago. The victory of Donald Trump in the U.S. presidential campaign and the successful “Leave” campaign in the UK Brexit referendum led the Oxford English Dictionary to select “post-truth” as word of the year for 2016. Since then, anti-elite populism across the North Atlantic has continued to gain victories, chief among them the 2018 victory of the Five Star Movement in Italy. As governments, foundations, academics, political activists, journalists, and civil society in democratic societies struggled to understand the overwhelming political results alongside the apparent information disorder, most observers’ eyes fell on technology. Social media, bots, hyper-targeted behavioral marketing—all have been seen as culprits or at least catalysts in public conversations. Technology has altered the foundations of news and media, and as trust in media continues to decline, artificial intelligence, machine learning, and algorithms have come to play a critical role not only as threats to the integrity and quality of media, but also as a source of potential solutions.

The core threats to information quality associated with AI include:

- **Algorithmic curation.** Most commonly known as the “filter bubble” concern, algorithms designed by platforms to keep users engaged produce ever-more refined rabbit holes down which users can go in a dynamic of reinforcement learning that leads them to ever-more extreme versions of their beliefs and opinions.
- **Bots.** Improvements in automation allow bots to become ever-more-effective simulations of human participants, thereby permitting propagandists to mount large-scale influence campaigns on social media by simulating larger and harder-to-detect armies of automated accounts.
- **Fake reports and videos.** Improving automated news reporting and manipulation of video and audio may enable the creation of seemingly authentic videos of political actors that will irrevocably harm their reputations and become high-powered vectors for false reporting.
- **Targeted behavioral marketing powered by algorithms and machine-learning.** Here, the concern is that the vast amounts of individually-identifiable data about users will allow ever-improving algorithms to refine the stream of content that individuals receive so as to manipulate their political opinions and behaviors.

Our approach to this set of issues is through the analysis of very large datasets, covering millions of stories, tweets, and Facebook shares, across diverse platforms reflecting national presidential politics in America from April 2015 to the present. The results of our work suggest that emphasizing the particular and technological, rather than the interaction of technology, institutions, and culture in a particular historical context, may lead to systematic overstating of the importance of technology, both positive and negative. Many studies do not attempt to address the impact of AI and other technologically-mediated phenomena that they identify and measure, but rather are focused on identifying and describing observable practices. In our own work, we have repeatedly found bots, Russian influence campaigns, and “fake news” of the nihilistic political clickbait variety; in all these contexts, we have found these technologically-mediated phenomena to be background noise, rather than a major driver of the observed patterns of political communication. Excessive attention to these technology-centric phenomena risks masking the real political-cultural dynamics that have confounded American political communication.

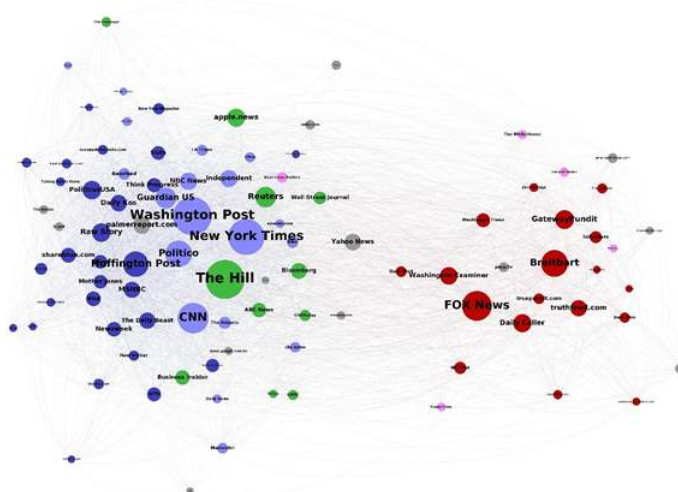
Studying media ecosystems

We study propaganda and disinformation in political communication through the lens of media ecosystems. The springboard for our research is a tool built in a decade-long collaboration between our Berkman Klein Center team and our colleagues at MIT Media Lab’s Center for Civic Media: [Media Cloud](#). Media Cloud enables us to discover media network structures that form around specific topics and to shed light on media frames, attention, and influence. Our early work centered on discrete legislative and regulatory controversies, such as [net neutrality](#) and the [SOPA-PIPA bills](#). As election year approached in 2016 we turned our attention to the presidential race.

Initially, we analyzed the 18 months leading up to the November 8 vote. The [Columbia Journalism Review](#) published our preliminary findings in February 2017, and we followed with a more complete [analysis of pre-election media](#) in August of last year. Since then we have expanded our research to include analysis of the election's aftermath, and have combined the election-period study with a review of the first year of the Trump presidency into a book coming out with Oxford University Press in September 2018, entitled *Network Propaganda: Manipulation, Disinformation, and Radicalization in American Politics*. With the support of the [Ethics and Governance of Artificial Intelligence Fund](#), we focused attention on the impact of artificial intelligence and automation on political public media. This work is motivated by the need to better understand the character, scope, and origins of the issue as an essential element in crafting corrective measures. Here we summarize our preliminary conclusions as well as the work of a growing number of researchers investing in this space.

Disinformation problems are fundamentally political and social—not technological

Our research leads us to conclude that political and social factors, not technology, are at the root of current media and information quality problems in American political communication. We analyze the linking, tweeting, Facebook sharing, and text of four million stories related to presidential politics published over a period of nearly three years before and after the 2016 presidential election. Relying on this data, we mapped out media source networks in open web media (online news, blogs, etc.) and on Twitter to learn how media sources clumped together based on similar cross-media linking and sharing patterns. This revealed a startling finding: media sources are, as many have observed, deeply polarized; but they are aligned in a distinctly asymmetric pattern. There is, as it turns out, not a simple left-right division in American political media. Instead, the divide is between the right and the rest of the political media spectrum. Media sources ranging from those with editorial voices that lean towards the center-right, such as the Wall Street Journal, all the way to distinctly left voices such as Mother Jones or the Daily Kos, comprise a single interconnected media ecosystem. In this portion of the media spectrum, attention is normally distributed around a peak focus on mainstream professional journalism outlets and journalistic values and mainstream professional journalism continue to exercise significant constraint on the survivability and spread of falsehoods. By contrast, there is a large gap between media sources in this broad center to center-left to left cluster and media sources on the right. Moreover, attention on the right increases as one moves further from the center, and peaks around media sites that are exclusively right-wing.



■ Left ■ Center-Left ■ Center ■ Center-Right ■ Right

Network map based on Twitter media sharing from January 22, 2017, to January 21, 2018. Nodes are sized by number of Twitter shares.

When we took a closer look at the substance and practices of journalism from the center of the spectrum to its poles, we found major differences in behavior. Media sources on the left and right extremes of the spectrum are prone to sacrificing accuracy in favor of partisan messaging, making them also prone to the spread of disinformation. However, the accountability and fact-checking mechanisms in the media structures on the center and center-left provide a barrier against further propagation and a check on shoddy reporting from the left. Media outlets that strive for objectivity and balance are less susceptible to spreading disinformation.

The leading media in the right-wing cluster follow a distinctly different strategy, and repeatedly amplify and accredit, rather than dampen or correct, bias-confirming falsehoods and misleading framings of facts. We find that insular conservative media lack the will or capacity to adhere to objectivity and accuracy in their reporting. Infowars, Gateway Pundit, and conservative political clickbait are a problem, but a bigger problem is when Drudge Report, Breitbart, and Fox News—conservative media sources with much larger audiences—amplify conspiratorial and deceptive stories. This creates a significant gap in information quality for readers of conservative-leaning sources of news relative to those who consume media sources outside the right-wing ecosystem, including left-wing sites.

Algorithmic curation and filter bubbles

It is important to understand that if filter bubbles or algorithmic curation were the primary reason for polarization, we would expect to see symmetric patterns of attention clustering by populations of audiences and publisher—all of whom are at the same technological frontier. The stark asymmetry between the right and the rest strongly suggests that differences in political culture and, we argue in our book, institutionally-driven media history of right-wing media, particularly talk radio and Fox News, drove the right into a media dynamic we call the propaganda feedback loop. This occurred before major Internet sites developed; Internet sites adapted to that already-operative media dynamic, rather than causing it.

Indeed, when we compare the pre-election coverage and the post-election coverage, attention on the left has shifted more to the center, while attention on the right has remained as right-oriented. Fox News has become more prominent online relative to Breitbart, but at the price of becoming more purely focused on right-oriented content than it was during the election. Fox online has lost hyperlinks from the center-right and center even more than from the center-left and left, and gained links from the right. This pattern is not the simple product of algorithmic filter bubbles. Compared to influence metrics based on social media attention, weblinks are more insulated from platform-imposed algorithms as they reflect the judgment and linking decisions of web authors, rather than attention and sharing patterns of audiences. Nonetheless, the asymmetric polarization appears by this measure too, and it is by this measure that Fox itself has moved to the right since the 2016 election.

Bots

Over the course of the year we have developed our own versions of several of the most widely-used bot-detection algorithms. We reran all of our analyses after removing accounts that were identified as “bots” by various methods. Although we do in fact identify a good number of accounts that would be considered “bots” by many of these definitions, the overall architecture of communication we observe remains unchanged whether we include these accounts or not. Without stronger evidence that particular major communications dynamics have been swayed by bots, our macro-level observations leave us skeptical as to the importance of bots. Moreover, using micro-scale case studies, we observe bots as background noise rather than as impactful interventions.

Functional and structural differences

Today’s media ecosystems are of course inseparable from technology, but if technology was at the core of the disinformation problem, we would expect to see as much disinformation on one side of the spectrum as the other. And yet, that’s not the case. The asymmetry we observe in the structure and practices of media across the U.S. political spectrum is evidence that the dynamics and problems in modern day media cannot be explained by technology alone.

Our caution should not be taken as clear evidence that algorithms are unimportant. There is little doubt in our minds that algorithms and machine learning impact media manipulation and disinformation. In large-scale digital media platforms, algorithms serve a curatorial role and act as gatekeepers, and are subject to gaming and manipulation in ways that human editors are not. In our own research, we have seen, for example, that Twitter is littered with disinformation and false accounts, some of which are bots and others sockpuppets. Moreover, we observe that the spread of disinformation is worse on Facebook than on Twitter, and on Twitter than on the open web. Moreover, we observed that, as Facebook was making its algorithm changes over the year, certain of the worst offenders on both the left and the right lost prominence and attention, although new offenders quickly took their place. In our current work we continue to monitor the differences across platforms and to find measures by which to assess the effectiveness of

algorithm changes on Facebook or Twitter on the spread of disinformation and misinformation, and, perhaps most importantly, to assess the impact of these changes on the media ecosystem as a whole.

Diagnoses, conclusions, and interventions should be based on systemic observations of impact, rather than individual observations of “bad behavior”

The media manipulation problem and the public attention afforded it have created an environment of urgency. Insights and research are key to mitigating some of this pressure, but the temptation to leap to assumptions of impact from any observable phenomenon is hard to resist. We are naturally drawn to the novel: trolls, clickbait factories, social media algorithms, targeted advertising, psychographic profiling, and Russian interference captivate the imagination and compel question and inquiry. Identifying instances of such interventions is technically challenging, and when we see hard work bear fruit it is tempting to attribute high importance to these observations. Nonetheless, without a baseline against which to assess the impact of one or several of these phenomena, it is impossible to justify assigning them the importance that they currently receive, or to design interventions that properly address the actually important interventions rather than those that are observable and salient.

Putting these novelties into perspective is hampered by our ability to fully and accurately measure media consumption. Audiences reached by misleading and false articles and media sources is measured in the millions. As prolific as this sounds, as described previously this ultimately is a small portion of content and exposure. A second point of uncertainty relates to impact and persuasion—there is scant evidence that false media stories have any impact in changing behavior.

A prime example is Russian efforts to influence election-related discourse. Although information around the number of accounts, posts, and impressions seems to be updated regularly, current numbers draw into question the true significance of their reach. In October 2017, Facebook [revealed](#) that approximately 80,000 pieces of content published by the now infamous Russian-operated Internet Research Agency were introduced to 29 million people between January 2015 and August 2017. Their subsequent likes and shares increased the reach of the posts to 126 million Facebook users. This is indeed a big scary number. But what we don’t know is how much user attention this content commanded among the many billions of stories and posts that comprised the news feeds of U.S. voters, or if it changed any minds or influenced voter behavior. For example, using one of the tools we developed for this project, we can track the appearance of a given string across Facebook public facing pages, Twitter, Reddit, Instagram, and the first few posts in 4chan discussions on a timeline down to the minute or second (depending on the platform). Using that utility, we tracked a particular story with strong indications of Russian influence (about John Podesta participating in satanic rituals), and compared all accounts to both the congressionally-released list of Russian Twitter accounts and an additional list of tens of thousands of accounts that are highly likely to be Russian bots or sockpuppets. While we did observe that 5–15% of the accounts were of such provenance at any given minute, the timing and pattern of their participation was unremarkable—a background presence of more-or-less stable existence, rather than a strategic intervention in either timing or in direction, and they therefore did not seem to play an important role in increasing the salience of the story in total or by tweeting it specifically at the major actors who were central in propagating the lie—Wikileaks, Infowars, or, ultimately, Sean Hannity.

It is critical not to confound the observation of a novel phenomenon with its actual impact in the world; newness is no proxy for impact. Indeed the discovery of such phenomena is important, but the messaging around the discovery should not be conflated with evidence that the discovered behavior in fact had impact.

The rapid advancement of technologies that digitally manipulate sound, images, and videos is a source of growing anxiety. It is too soon to predict whether synthetic media will exacerbate media disorder and epistemic crisis, but if fabricated media are shared, consumed, and interpreted in ways similar to the current versions of deceptive media, it will be spread or contained by the same influential social, political, and media entities. The fantastical nature of the claims that were widely believed by significant numbers of voters—nearly half of Trump voters gave some credence to rumors that someone associated with the Clinton campaign was running a pedophilia ring—suggests that social identity, much more than any technical indicia of truth, are the foundation for beliefs and attitudes about political matters.

Our work greatly benefits by consciously focusing on the disinformation forest, rather than on its individual trees. With an eye toward the long-term dynamics between institutions, culture, and technology, we look at algorithms and technology as a relatively new element integrated into the dynamics of broader media systems while keeping grasp of many more traditional vectors and structures. We look across media and across platforms, considering the enduring influence of radio and cable alongside broadcast television and social media platforms. Indeed, a combination of open web media publication and social media network mapping greatly enhances our understanding of the likely impact of bots, sockpuppets, political clickbait, foreign intervention, and microtargeting. Although prolific in absolute terms, the role of these modern vectors of disinformation plays an important but modest role in the overall media ecosystem.

It doesn't look like AI is coming to the rescue anytime soon, if ever

There are a number of ways in which AI may help us to address information quality issues, including:

- Automated detection and flagging of false stories; algorithmic tools to point readers to corrections and fact-checking.
- Algorithmic tools to detect and defend against coordinated attacks by propagandists.
- Computational aids to “nudge” of readers and users to expose themselves to media and reporting outside of their echo chambers, thus opening their eyes to a broader range of viewpoints.

Despite the strong advances in the field, there is little indication at present that these tools will be able to serve as independent arbiters of truth, salience, or value. Repeatedly in our work, we have seen that stories built around a kernel of true facts, framed and interpreted in materially misleading ways are more important than stories made of clear falsifiable claims. Moreover, the meaning of stories often emerges from the network of stories and frames within which they are located. Stories and their interpretation—and misinterpretation—draw upon and act through existing social and political structures and narratives. As seen in existing applications, AI is effective at channeling and amplifying sentiments and interests of affinity groups, and helping people in ways that they want to be helped, but no present efforts appear to be able to diagnose the level of subtlety involved in the most important present disinformation campaigns we have been studying.

Systemic responses are required to address systemic issues

So what do we do about all of this? There is no silver bullet, but the best thing we can do is to continue to work toward systemic responses to the systemic problems undermining today's media ecosystem and information quality. We must continue to focus attention on rebuilding and strengthening the political and civic institutions that undergird a well functioning democracy. The insights described here draw primarily on research conducted in the United States, but we need ecosystem-based analyses of media systems in more countries to understand how the vulnerabilities, resilience, and dynamics differ across different political and cultural contexts.

Strengthening media accountability mechanisms is vital, and tamping down disinformation and media manipulation is an integral part of the everyday hard work of democracy and governance. But given the perils of placing constraints on political speech, taking a careful and cautious approach to regulation is essential. It is important to be similarly circumspect in what we require of social media companies in addressing disinformation.

Last but far from least, there is still much work to be done in understanding the nature, reach, and impact of disinformation, as well as monitoring and evaluating targeted efforts to inoculate readers and inhibit the spread of disinformation. An area of particular concern is the increasing concentration of research capability and political outreach capability in a few private hands. We must continue efforts to bolster public interest research initiatives and develop and implement structures that allow researchers access to key sources of data with mechanisms in place to ensure robust and ethical research standards.

The development, application, and capabilities of AI-based systems are evolving rapidly, leaving largely unanswered a broad range of important short- and long-term questions related to the social impact, governance, and ethical implementations of these technologies and practices. Over the past year, the [Berkman Klein Center](#) and the [MIT Media Lab](#), as anchor institutions of the [Ethics and Governance of Artificial Intelligence Fund](#), have initiated projects in areas such as social and criminal justice, media and information quality, and global governance and inclusion, in order to provide guidance to decision-makers in the private and public sectors, and to engage in impact-oriented pilot projects to bolster the use of AI for the public good, while also building an institutional knowledge base on the ethics and governance of AI, fostering human capacity, and strengthening interfaces with industry and policy-makers. Over this initial year, we have learned a lot about the challenges and opportunities for impact. This snapshot provides a brief look at some of those lessons and how they inform our work going forward.

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3.3: Fake News and Fake Solutions- How Do We Build a Civics of Trust?

By Ivan Sigal, from Global Voices [AdVox](#), March 20, 2017. Licensed under a CC-BY license.

Posted 20 March 2017 16:37 GMT



Protesters fly a flag upside down as a signal of distress outside the offices of The Washington Post in Washington D.C. on Inauguration Day, January 20, 2017. Photo: Ivan Sigal.

In his recent [manifesto](#), Mark Zuckerberg asserts that the response to our dysfunctional and conflict-ridden politics is to build a stronger global community based on ubiquitous interconnection. We know of course that Facebook stands to profit from this utopian vision, and we should be skeptical of the motives underlying Zuck's position. But it's worth taking a second look at the idea of working on underlying economic and political issues in our societies, rather than focusing on the effects of online expression—particularly in the context of the moral panic over “fake news.”

The consternation about fake news from Western journalists, scholars of propaganda, and policymakers has inspired waves of stories and [talk-shops addressing](#) its growth as a threat to our public discourse, our journalism, and our systems of governance. And we see many attempts to understand, fix, or apportion blame. Yet many of the proposed fixes are deeply problematic because they advocate overly broad and vague restrictions on expression. Solutions that would limit suspected “fake” expression or strongly encourage private intermediaries to restrict some kinds of speech and prioritize or “whitelist” others are particularly troubling.

This week, Germany was the latest country to [introduce](#) a plan that would force social media companies to monitor and censor some kinds of online expression. Justice minister Heiko Maas [wants](#) to put regulatory pressure on social media companies, and especially Facebook and Twitter, to police expression, asserting that they have failed to do so voluntarily. Draft legislation proposes to fine social media companies up to €50 million for failure to quickly delete hate speech, fake news, and other types of misleading speech.

In this context, we can look to countries that have created regulatory regimes to control online expression — such as China — not as entirely “other”, but perhaps as cautionary examples. When posing solutions to fix fake news, we should be extremely careful not to build our own self-censorship machines.

“Fake” news and the role of states

Many recent false news stories have come from groups not affiliated with states, but examples from Russia, China, Iran and many other countries should remind us that the biggest threat to our public discourse is false information used by and to the advantage of governments. Governments, after all, have the authority to couple shifting narratives of truth to state mechanisms of control. We ought to be especially attuned to states that restrict the “false” expression of their citizens, while at the same time creating

misleading narratives and stories about themselves. When states attempt to control narratives, it's time to start looking for signs of tyranny.

For the past 20 years, we have seen states or their affiliates use Internet-based false news and disinformation as part of broader agendas to shape public opinion for political ends. Well-researched examples include China's [50 Cent Party](#), Russia's [troll factories](#), and astroturfing [bot engines](#) contracted by the U.S. government, all of which are designed to flood Internet forums and social media with falsities and distractions.

At the same time, some states have [taken steps](#) to regulate, restrict and even criminalize “false” stories produced by citizens and journalists as a punitive method of controlling expression. In Bahrain, [China](#), Egypt, Turkey, Russia, Venezuela, Iran and elsewhere social media users have been arrested and prosecuted for sharing information deemed by governments to be false or misinformed. [New regulations](#) in China forbid the use of “unverified facts distributed via social media platforms” and prohibit websites “from quoting from unnamed or fake news sources and fabricating news based on hearsay, guesswork or imagination.”

A [recent declaration](#) issued by a group of intergovernmental organizations, including UN Rapporteur for Freedom of Expression [David Kaye](#), discusses these regulatory efforts from the perspective of international law and norms. They emphasize that international human rights doctrine explicitly protects expression that may differ from or counter governmental positions, even when it is factually inaccurate. Regulatory and technical approaches to reduce fake news should, they argue, continue to safeguard the diversity and abundance of speech. They write:

the human right to impart information and ideas is not limited to “correct” statements...the right also protects information and ideas that may shock, offend and disturb, and that prohibitions on disinformation may violate international human rights standards, while, at the same time, this does not justify the dissemination of knowingly or recklessly false statements by official or State actors...

What's the problem, exactly?

The real-life consequences of fake news are unclear. A recent [study](#) by the MIT/Harvard research project [Media Cloud](#), (with which Global Voices is [affiliated](#)), led by [Yochai Benkler](#) and [Ethan Zuckerman](#), examines the effects of right-wing information sources in the U.S. It suggests that rather than wringing our hands over “fake news”, we should focus on disinformation networks that are insulated from mainstream public conversations. Benkler and his colleagues challenge the idea that “the internet *as a technology* is what fragments public discourse and polarizes opinions” and instead argue that “human choices and political campaigning, not one company’s algorithm” are the more likely factor to influence the construction and dissemination of disinformation.

Nevertheless, projects seeking to control fake news are running full steam ahead. These efforts have the potential to affect what information is easily available to publics, and if we aren’t careful, could even diminish our rights to expression. Approaches tend to fall into three broad categories:

- Fix online discourse by nudging technologies that control or censor some categories of speech
- Fix the public by making us better at distinguishing fact from fallacy
- Fix journalism, generally with massive cash transfers from the technology sector

Notably, these approaches all focus on mitigating effects rather than confronting the underlying economic or technical incentives in the structure of media, or the broader social, economic and political incentives that motivate speech.

Fix online discourse

In seeking to build systems to manage false news, technology companies will end up creating systems to monitor and police speech. We will quickly find that they need to use ever-more granular, vigilant and therefore continuously updated semantic analysis in order to find and restrict expression.

These proposed solutions to fake news would be in part technological, based on AI and natural language processing. They will automate the search for and flagging of certain terms, word associations, and linguistic formulations. But language is more malleable than algorithm, and we will find that people will invent alternative terms and locutions to express their ends.

The slipperiness of language could cause the hunt for “fake” or hurtful speech to become an end in itself. We have already seen this in the hunt for “toxic” language in a recent project called [Perspective](#), made by Google’s [Jigsaw](#), and other efforts will surely follow.

Companies are likely to supplement their automated processes with human monitoring — from social media platform users flagging suspect content to contractor armies interpreting those flags and implementing restrictions. Added to this, perhaps, will be ombudspeople, feedback loops, legal processes, and policy controls upon the censors. Those systems are [already in place](#) to deal with terrorism, extreme hate speech, extreme violence, child pornography, and nudity and sexual arousal. They can be further refined and expanded to police other types of expression.

Proposed solutions in this vein mostly fail to acknowledge that the technological incentives that encourage fake news are the same as the forces that currently finance the digital media industry — that is, advertising technology masquerading as editorial content.

The internet theorist Doc Searls calls this “[adtech](#)”, emphasizing that it is a form of direct marketing or spamming. The rise of fake news is driven in part by organizations seeking revenues or political influence by creating sensational and misleading stories packaged for highly polarized audiences. Producers of this content benefit from a system already [designed to segment](#) and mobilize audiences for commercial ends. That system includes the monitoring of consumer habits, targeted advertising, direct marketing and the creation of editorial products appealing to specific consumer segments. These forces coalesce in a dance of editorial and advertising incentives that leads to further polarization and segmentation.

Fix the public

The next approach — that we fix ourselves — relies on the Victorian idea that our media systems would work if only people behaved in ways expected of them by the builders of systems. [Media literacy](#) campaigns, public education, fact-checking, calling out and shaming tactics, media diets, whitelists of approved media: these solutions require that we blame ourselves for failing to curb our appetites. It is not wrong to suggest that we are susceptible to the allure of the media’s endorphin-injection strategy to hook us on the sensational and trivial, or that education is important for a healthy civics. To focus blame primarily on individuals, however, is victim-blaming of a sort.

Fix journalism

The third approach — devoting more resources to better journalism, is an example of the journalism community jumping on the current moment to reassert their expertise and value. While a more proactive, better-resourced media is definitely vital for the long-term health of our civic life, conversations about journalism need to start with the [trust deficit](#) many journalistic outfits have accumulated over the past decades. That deficit exists precisely because of ever-more sensational and facile reporting, news as entertainment, and the corporate drive to maximise profits over the interests of audiences and readers.

Given that the business model of the liberal, capitalist media is primarily to sell eyeballs to advertisers, they should not be surprised to find those of us being sold becoming wise to the approach. And while efforts to strengthen journalism and public trust in the media are important and much-needed, they will not make fake news go away.

So what are we really talking about?

The technological and the human-based approaches to controlling inaccurate online speech proposed to date for the most part do not address the underlying social, political or communal causes of hateful or false expression. Instead, they seek to restrict behaviors and control effects, and they rely on the good offices of our technology intermediaries for that service. They do not ask us to look more closely at the social and political construction of our communities. They do not examine and propose solutions to address hate, discrimination and bias in our societies, in issues such as income disparity, urban planning, educational opportunity, or, in fact, our structures of governance.

Frustratingly, we have seen these approaches before, in [efforts](#) to reduce online “extremism”, and also with [dubious](#) results. Countering violent extremism (CVE) projects suffer from similar [definitional flaws](#) about the nature of the problem, but that doesn’t stop governments from creating misguided responses. For examples, look to the many ‘counter-narrative’ [projects](#) such as “[Welcome to ISIS Land](#)” funded by the U.S. State Department. These projects, supported by [governments](#), [international organizations](#), and [companies](#), seek an array of technical, communications and policy-based approaches to controlling extremism.

[A video originally embedded here from YouTube is no longer available.]

David Kaye, in an earlier joint declaration on CVE, [notes](#) the “fail[ure] to provide definitions for key terms, such as ‘extremism’ or ‘radicalization’”. “In the absence of a clear definition, these terms can be used to restrict a wide range of lawful expression,” but still [inflict collateral damage](#), with pervasive surveillance and tracking that triggers the self-censor in all of us, resulting in the reduction of civic participation and dialogue.

How do we begin to tackle the larger challenges, those beyond simple technological fixes or self-blame? There are no easy solutions for the economic and social inequities that create divisions, and the technological and economic incentives that underpin our current information ecosystem are deeply entrenched. Yet we need to find a way to start serious conversations about these systemic challenges, rather than tinkering with their effects or simply assigning responsibility to the newest players on the field.

Sir Tim Berners-Lee, the inventor of the internet, has [urged](#) that we reform the systems and business models we have created to fund our online lives. He points, for example, to the use of personal data by companies as the driver for the creation of surveillance societies, which exerts chilling effects on free expression. He suggests seeking alternatives to the concentration of attention and power in the hands of a small number of social media companies that derive profit from showing us content that is “surprising, shocking, or designed to appeal to our biases.” He’s concerned by the use of these same tactics in political advertising, and its effect on our systems of electoral politics.

Confronting our social and economic inequities is even harder. It is the challenge of our time to find the language to conduct honest and frank debate about how we construct our economies and our states, how we apportion benefits, and which values guide us. Building civic communities that are rooted in trust, both online and off, is the ongoing and vital work necessary for public conversations about our collective future.

It is no small irony that the communications systems that we built to support such debate are imperiled, both by those who would explode the social norms of civic discourse for their ideological ends, and through resultant attempts to control extreme or misleading expression. It is easy to find fault with the technologies that facilitate our collective civic life. It is much more difficult to look at our civic life as a whole and determine whether and how it may be failing.

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3.4: 3 Ways Facebook and Other Social Media Companies Could Clean Up Their Acts – If They Wanted To

Reprinted from [The Conversation](#), December 7, 2018.



Under fire, but not without options.

[AP Photo/Francois Mori](#)

[Anthony M. Nadler](#), [Ursinus College](#) and [Matthew Crain](#), [Miami University](#)

Facebook is in crisis mode, but the company can take major steps to fix itself – and the [global community](#) it says it wants to promote. Facebook founder, CEO and majority shareholder Mark Zuckerberg need not wait for [governments to impose regulations](#). If he and other industry leaders wanted to, they could make meaningful changes fairly quickly.

It wouldn't be painless, but Facebook in particular is in a world of hurt already, facing criticism for [contributing to civil unrest](#) and [sectarian turmoil](#) around the world, delayed responses to [disinformation campaigns](#), [misleading users](#) about [data-handling policies](#), and [efforts to discredit critics](#) – not to mention a [budding employee revolt](#).

Facebook, Twitter, Google and other social media companies are causing [society-wide damage](#). But they tend to describe the problems as much smaller, resulting from [rogue individuals and groups](#) hijacking their systems for nefarious purposes. Our [research](#) into how social media can be exploited by manipulative political operatives, conducted with Joan Donovan at the [Data & Society](#) research institute, suggests the real problem is much larger than these companies admit.

We believe the roots lie in their [extremely profitable advertising systems](#), which need a major overhaul. We have identified some key changes that these giant powerhouses could make right away. These moves could reduce opportunities for political manipulation and limit the [harm to democratic societies](#) around the world.

Users' minds in the crosshairs

Facebook, Google, Twitter and other social media companies have built an enormous [digital influence machine](#) powered by user tracking, targeting, testing and automated decision-making to make advertising more effective and efficient. While building this supercharged surveillance system, companies have [promised users](#) and [regulators](#) that targeted advertising is mutually beneficial for both consumers and advertisers.

In this bargain, users are supposed to receive more relevant ads. Facebook, for instance, explains that its “interest-based advertising” serves users who “[want to see ads that relate to things they care about](#).” It’s true that these methods can identify ads that connect with users’ actual interests. But the very same data-driven techniques that tell a surfer about a new board design can also identify strategic points where people are [most vulnerable to influence](#).

In particular, the leading social media advertising systems let political operatives [experiment with different ads](#) to see which are the most effective. They can use these tools not only to see if certain issues resonate with particular targets but also test for fears or prejudices that can be invoked to influence political behavior.



This misleading ad impersonated racial justice activists to urge black Americans not to vote for Hillary Clinton.

[U.S. House of Representatives Subcommittee on Intelligence – Democrats](#)

One key way to do this is to make people feel that someone else represents an emotionally charged [threat to their identity](#). In 2016, for instance, Russia-linked operatives bought [thousands of Facebook ads](#) targeted to specific audiences suggesting Hillary Clinton had insulted their group’s dignity or threatened their safety. Some ads alleged [Clinton espoused disrespect](#) for specific occupations, like coal miners, or racial groups, like African-Americans. [Others claimed](#) she would confiscate guns or supported radical political movements seeking to overturn familiar ways of life.

Targeting political ads is not unique to online advertising, but the tools of digital ad systems are vastly more powerful than traditional mass media. Advertisers can try out [several versions of an ad simultaneously](#) and receive almost instant feedback on which ones most effectively drive specific audiences to share, like or comment on them. This [digital feedback loop](#) helps political operatives refine their tactics, probing for just the right images, words and emotions to influence very specific subgroups of citizens.

Move fast and fix things

Members of [Congress](#) and even some key [Silicon Valley figures](#) have begun discussing the need for tighter [government oversight](#) and [greater accountability](#) in digital advertising. Change need not wait for politics.

Based on our analysis, here are some steps companies could take right away – on their own. These moves may hurt the firms’ finances, but would demonstrate serious and lasting commitment to limiting their platforms’ usefulness in political manipulation campaigns.

As their first move, social media companies could stop allowing their ad services to be used as freewheeling experimental laboratories for examining their users’ psyches. Just as [marketers](#) and [academic researchers](#) must obtain permission from their test subjects, political advertisers that run online ad experiments could get [informed consent in advance](#) from every user who is involved. Companies should ask for users’ consent in specific notifications about ad experiments and not penalize users for opting out by limiting their access to services. We suspect many users would opt out of these tests if given the choice, but in any case this policy would help draw public attention to the hidden manipulation tools that platforms offer to their real customers: the political and commercial advertisers who pay the bills.

Make targeted political advertising transparent

To increase transparency and limit the ability of special interests to secretly influence politics, social media companies could refuse to work with so-called [dark money](#) groups. All political advertisers should be required to disclose their major donors in a format users can easily access.

A new policy banning dark money ads would respond to evidence that political operatives have used impersonation and manipulative ad tactics to [stir in-fighting or sow division](#) among coalitions of their adversaries. Impersonation clearly work best when ad sponsors are able to hide their identities and motives. Anonymous ads are also more likely to violate ethical standards simply because no one fears being held responsible for them.

Make platforms more democratic

A more significant change social media companies could make would be to introduce democratic oversight of how they collect and use people's data.

Facebook's Zuckerberg recently took an initial step in this direction, announcing that he will create [independent review panels](#) to handle users' appeals against the company's removal of content it judges inappropriate. He explained that he wanted to ensure "[these decisions are made](#) in the best interests of our community and not for commercial reasons."

Whatever you think about this plan – and it has been greeted with plenty of [skepticism](#) – Zuckerberg's reasoning acknowledges that because social platforms have become so central to democratic life, their own policies and design decisions require democratic accountability.

A more ambitious vision would let independent ethics panels representing diverse communities of users set enforceable policies for ethical political advertising. Similar sorts of groups are common in [medicine](#) and are emerging in [artificial intelligence](#), among other fields. The details of [how such committees operate](#) will be critical to their success. If these committees are set up in partnership with nonprofit organizations with proven records of advocating for [democratic communication](#) and [campaign finance transparency](#), perhaps they could help social media companies earn greater public trust by prioritizing democracy over maximizing their profits.

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CHAPTER OVERVIEW

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4.1: Reddit- The Conversation Starts Here



Reddit logo, via [Wikimedia](#).

What is Reddit?

Reddit is a forum-based website that was founded to create a space where communities could collaborate, share information on their lives and interests, and find other interests related to their current experience. The website [itself](#) is home to communities called subreddits.

Subreddits are separate forums hosted on the reddit website; each one centralizes on a different topic, brand, identity, or opinion. Reddit also curates a few subreddits for general and administration related topics, like [News and Announcements](#). Users can gain all sorts of opinions, advice, and camaraderie on Reddit from personal finance and legal insight, sharing with their coworkers from Target, Starbucks, or emergency medical services, or just finding primal human entertainment like pictures of cute cats or self-posted pornographic material of all genders.

Moderators are responsible for monitoring individual subreddits under a volunteer position, and **administrators** handle the website-wide affairs like technical specifications, site rules, and annual site performance, as well as supervising the moderators of different communities.

Users register to the site and can **subscribe** to different subreddits, which allows them to see a customized feed of posts from their favorite subreddits alongside posts that are popular across reddit.

Reddit defines its [mission](#) as “[being] home to thousands of communities, endless conversation, and authentic human connection. Whether you’re into breaking news, sports, TV fan theories, or a never-ending stream of the internet’s cutest animals, there’s a community on Reddit for you” (Reddit).

Who is Reddit?

Reddit was founded in 2005 by partners Alexis Ohanian and Steve Huffman. Throughout the years, the two have left and then rejoined the company, currently serving as co-CEOs.

In 2006, Reddit was sold to Conde Nast, a magazine company under Advance Publications. Conde Nast/Advance Publications also own various local news outlets, and magazines including *Allure*, *GQ*, *The New Yorker*, *Vogue*, *Vanity Fair*, and *Wired*. Since 2011, Reddit operates as an independent subsidiary of Advance Publications. Reddit today is [the sixth most visited website in the United States](#), and twenty-first most visited website across the world.

Who pays for Reddit?

Reddit has only a few main funding methods: [investor funding rounds](#), [selling advertisements](#), [premium membership options](#) and [returns on investing](#) in other tech companies.

Investor funding rounds allow private companies to use their company’s valuation and strategic plan to solicit funding from individual investors and investment firms, ultimately boosting the valuation and gaining liquid capital. Reddit’s latest funding round, which closed in February 2019, raised \$300 million from a variety of investors like Chinese firm Tencent Holdings Ltd, investment firms Sequoia Capital and Fidelity, and individuals including Snoop Dogg. Three prior funding rounds raised a combined \$250 million and has over twenty major investors. [Reddit’s last round of investor funding](#) was responsible for funding “internal product and business efforts” including new video capabilities, a new desktop design, and hiring to increase their workforce from 140 to 300 at the end of 2017.

Their current market valuation is \$3 billion and the last funding type was Series D. The letters used for different funding Series classifies the stage in which the corporation requesting funding is considered. Series D investments are reserved for established companies that have completed other funding rounds or proven themselves as a revenue-generator, and typically see \$10+ million in funding.

Another popular type of funding is the sale of **advertisement options** across the site. Advertisement options on Reddit include either a sponsored post on certain subreddits or types of subreddits, or the front page. Advertisers are charged based on the page views their ads get by the thousands, plus a base fee. Other advertisement use on Reddit includes Google AdSense advertisements on the sidebar.

As the website expands its advertising platform, Reddit has targeted ad sales towards fashion, media, and automotive companies; this raised \$85 to 100 million this year. Reddit only started selling structured advertising in 2015 and launched its app in early 2016, limiting the percentage of its revenue that came from advertisements. The company plans to expand its advertising platform in the future to take on Google and Facebook's ad programs.

Smaller revenue streams include the **sale of premium memberships** and **returns on investment in other tech companies**. Reddit's most notable investment went to [Imgur](#) in 2014 for a total of \$40 million.

The sale of Reddit Premium memberships and Reddit coins enables premium features to enhance user experience and the ability to turn-off ads. Newly revamped from the old Reddit Gold system in 2018, Reddit Premium costs \$5.99/mo and can either be purchased for oneself or gifted to other users for one week or one month by using reddit coins to give their comments or posts a Gold Award or Platinum Award. In 2017, Reddit Premium and coins made the site over \$1 million; the site is hoping these numbers are boosted with the aforementioned redesign recently debuting.

Reddit leaders have noted that [the company will not seek](#) another common method of financing, an **IPO/public offering sale**, in which companies sell shares of ownership in the company in exchange for liquid capital. Reddit has never publicly shared revenue figures, but owners have stated multiple times that prior to 2018/19, the site has not been profitable and most funds cover the operating cost of the website and its staff.

What data does it collect from its users?

Reddit collect three types of [data](#) which they described as information the consumer provided, information they collect automatically, and information they gather from others.

The information they collect from the user is username, password, email, user account preferences and settings. Reddit may log information when you access and use the Services. This may include your IP address, user-agent string, browser type, operating system, referral URLs, device information (e.g., device IDs), pages visited, links clicked, the requested URL, hardware settings, and search terms.

Reddit may receive information about the consumer from other sources, including from other users and third parties, and combine that information with the other information they have about the consumer. For example, Reddit may receive demographic or interest information about the consumer from third parties, including advertisers, and combine it with Reddit's own data using a common account identifier such as a hash of an email address or a mobile-device ID.

How does Reddit moderate its contributions?

Reddit uses a metric called **karma** to represent their contributions to Reddit. There are two kinds of karma: link and comment. Link karma is received when you post a link on Reddit, while comment karma is what you will receive when you post a comment. If others like your post or comment, they will give you upvotes. If others do not like the content you post, they will downvote it. Karma is measured by the total difference between all upvotes and downvotes on every link post or comment that redditors submitted.

Reddit allows its users to post various authentic contents that can either be funny, serious or offensive. However it has [a basic guideline](#) on what is prohibited or unwelcome on the platform. Reddit prohibits posting illegal content, involuntary pornography, contents that incite violence, personal information, and spam. All contents that might be banned from accessing at workplace, such as nudity, pornography, profanity must be tagged as NSFW (Not Safe For Work).

Most people follow Reddit for their personal interests, and most subreddits are considered non-news thread. However there are a few subreddits designed to update news around the world, including r/news. R/news claims to contain "real news articles, primarily but not exclusively, news relating to the United States and the rest of the World." Having more than 18 million followers, its popularity lies among the most subscribed subreddits in the entire domain.

R/news promotes ten different rules to control the flow of articles. For examples, the first rule dictates that any news that is more than a week old is not considered "news," to maintain the strict up-to-date nature of the page. Discussions regarding news should be kept in r/inthenews, which is another subreddit for opinion pieces.

Interestingly, news related to politics should be moved to R/politics. Therefore, this subreddit is not a suitable place for followers who look for inherently political materials.

Critiques of Reddit

While Reddit does appear to have a platform for everyone's voice to be heard there is an underlying issue that moderators have the power to censor any subreddits that do not adhere to the views they hold. This may lead to some users having a smaller voice in their community and discourage them in the future from participating.

Currently, Reddit has [moderator guidelines](#) with vague definitions of how moderators should behave, like being “around” to answer questions and solve problems, cultivating “healthy communities”, and allowing moderators to review appeals to their own actions.

Reddit also lends itself to be an anonymous forum where violent language could be exchanged, making many of its users fearful of death threats, threats of sexual violence, defamation, etc. Currently Reddit reserves the right to ban subreddits and utilize its quarantine method to limit exposure to subreddits.

Looking towards the future Reddit has the opportunity to change how their moderators work by strengthening the non-partisan ideals of moderatorship and encourage consistent action across subreddits, Reddit should shift the shape of their Moderator Guidelines.

First, converting the guidelines to requirements or another type of document requiring explicit acceptance of the rules would create a stronger infrastructure and sense of commitment to how Reddit would like moderators to behave.

Secondly, the terms of the current moderator guidelines need to be better defined. This could be done through either modeling exceptional subreddit moderator and moderator practices, or providing their own examples of how they would like to see moderation handled. For example, in the guidance for Stable and Active Teams of Moderators, Reddit should provide:

- appropriate frequency of participation on the subreddit,
- reasons acceptable for extended leaves,
- a process in which moderators are required to notify their team about extended leave,
- activity frequency guidelines under which a mod is demoted (for example, being missing for x amount of time, being present but not handling moderator duties for y amount of time, etc.)

A solution to abuses of anonymity on Reddit could be an additional financial sanction added to subreddits designated as free speech applicable, but not recommended for the general population. The financial sanction would require the subreddit to pay, collectively, to remain in existence and be hosted. The fee could be per-subscriber or collectively as a subreddit, and could be due annually or per month. The funds from these collections could be partially donated to causes that support human rights, social welfare, and freedom of speech.

The advantage to per-subscriber is that the financial cost would limit the popularity of said subreddits and would scale in terms of subreddit volume, but imposing a community-wide funding target would allow for the temporary suspension of the subreddit if it cannot “offset” itself by a certain contribution for charity, which creates some social good. An annual collection is a more forgiving method for collection and provides a set expectation, and again, the per-month collection discourages high volumes of traffic to the subreddit and maximizes potential to collect funds for charitable causes.

Recommended Reading

“[Reddit Raised \\$200 Million in Funding and Is Now Valued at \\$1.8 Billion](#)” by Kurt Wagner, Vox, July 21, 2017.

“[Reddit’s Co-Founders Sold the Company at Age 23 For a Fraction of the 1.8 Billion It’s Worth Today – Here’s How the Duo Got Back On Top](#),” Melia Robinson, *Business Insider*, Nov. 24, 2017.

4.1: [Reddit- The Conversation Starts Here](#) is shared under a [CC BY](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by LibreTexts.

4.2: Google



Google logo as of 2015 via [Wikimedia Commons](#)

Background

The history of Google began in 1995 when Stanford University student Larry Page met a man named Sergey Brin. They initially worked on a search engine called BackRub that was used at Stanford for about a year. It wasn't until September 15, 1997 that Google.com was registered. In 1998, Google was set as a private company and while a small startup in a garage with one employee, the future to come set up the path for the company to become the giant we know today.

Growth: In the first couple years of operation, the company received offers for a buyout, even going up to one million dollars. While Page and Brin considered this so they could go back to focus on their studies, they declined. In late 1999, google received a \$25 million dollar investment that significantly boosted its growth. Google's rise combined with the fall of the giant at the time, Yahoo, significantly helped Google grow and become the powerhouse it is today. As it grew, Google began to add more services such as ads, images, and a defining moment in 2005 when they added maps. Google expanded more and more from office to office and then worldwide. Eventually, Google's success lead them to invest in stuff of their own, for example investing 200 million dollars in a wind farm. They also bought YouTube for \$1.65 billion dollars. Today, Google's logo is one that half the world recognizes and it is one of the [most valuable companies](#) of our time. Also, Google has officially become the verb that people are widely acknowledge. There are so many more important [milestones](#) in Google's journey.

Google Today

Google is owned by Alphabet Inc. However, the Alphabet CEO is one of the original creators of Google, Larry Page. Google is currently run by a man named Sundar Pichai. Its stated mission is "to organize the world's information and make it universally accessible and useful" and, while they are very successful in their mission, Google goes much further than just that. Google is a giant service that provides the most recent news, email services, document services, and the list goes on and on. It is used in the everyday life of American people and other people around the world. It is not just a website but a platform to connect the world.

Financial

In its 2017 Annual report, Google reported it generates most of its revenues from advertising. This includes sales of apps, purchases made in-app, digital content products on Google and YouTube, Android, and licensing and service fees, including fees received for Google Cloud offerings. 46% of this was from clicks (cost per clicks), amounting to US\$109,652 million in 2017. This includes three principal methods, namely AdMob, AdSense (such as AdSense for Content, AdSense for Search, etc.) and DoubleClick AdExchange.

For the 2006 fiscal year, the company reported \$10.492 billion in total advertising revenues and only \$112 million in licensing and other revenues. In 2011, 96% of Google's revenue was derived from its advertising programs. In addition to its own algorithms for understanding search requests, Google uses technology from a company they acquired, DoubleClick, to project user interest and target advertising to the search context and the user history.

In 2007, Google launched "AdSense for Mobile", taking advantage of the emerging mobile advertising market.

Google Analytics allows website owners to track where and how people use their website, for example by examining click rates for all the links on a page. Google advertisements can be placed on third-party websites in a two-part program. Google's AdWords allows advertisers to display their advertisements in the Google content network, through a cost-per-click scheme. The sister service, Google AdSense, allows website owners to display these advertisements on their website and earn money every time ads are clicked. One of the criticisms of this program is the possibility of click fraud, which occurs when a person or automated script clicks on advertisements without being interested in the product, causing the advertiser to pay money to Google unduly. Industry reports in 2006 claimed that approximately 14 to 20 percent of clicks were fraudulent or invalid.

Data

Like any other website or forum that you can create an account on, Google gathers information about people, which can be concerning for some. Google has access to your name, birthday, and gender, your password and phone number, emails you write and receive on Gmail, photos and videos you save, Docs, Sheets, and Slides you create on Drive, comments you make on YouTube, contacts you add, and calendar events.

News

There are two ways that users can find news on Google. The first way Google can represent news is by using its search engine that helps users find the most relevant news. How Google does this is by matching our search keywords with texts from different websites which will be relevant to our search. Users often try to place their sites prominently by using Search Engine Optimization, attempting to influence the order in which website/pages appear when we search for something. We can also think of Google and the internet as the internet being like a Library and Google like the librarian who shows us the information which it thinks might be useful for us. Since Google's results ranking algorithm is proprietary, we really can't know for sure how it works.

The only limit that available right now is the keywords choice from users because Google Search Algorithm gives user more accurate result base on the region of users. Suppose we have users in the US and users in Asia countries search for the same topic, there are chances that Google gives different results. We can consider how different the search result that users in some countries like North Korea and China will get from users in Europe or America. Also, this sorting algorithm is based on the keywords of your search, and since not everyone typing an idea the same way, different search results will appear based on the keywords that they look up. The results might also be affected by the location of user. This is the main idea of this search algorithm: "Search algorithms look at many factors, including the words of your query, relevance and usability of pages, expertise of sources, and your location and settings." As the company [explains](#),

With the amount of information available on the web, finding what you need would be nearly impossible without some help sorting through it. Google ranking systems are designed to do just that: sort through hundreds of billions of webpages in our Search index to find the most relevant, useful results in a fraction of a second, and present them in a way that helps you find what you're looking for.

The second way is using [Google News](#). Every user that has a Google account can use this function. This function has a headlines newsfeed and also offer users specific categories that users are looking for. This is a nice feature of Google that allows user update news constantly. Google uses sources from popular channel like Fox News, CNN and *The New York Times*. Google shows the sources with the title so users can have multiple options to choose for their sources.

The News feature is [developing fact checking tools](#) to helps users check the accountability of their source of news. This is an extremely helpful tools for social and political violence because this feature does not just representing news but it is also show articles that respond and warn people about the fake news that some unreliable sources posted.

Since Google will show users different results base on users keywords, there might be a chance that Google will also show the unreliable sources. However, the ranking systems will also help to prevent those unreliable sources from appearing on the front sites of the search so unless users look for those sources on purpose but, there is no possible way to completely eliminate this.

[Some people](#) are able to push unreliable sources onto the front by taking advantage of phrases that may not be as mainstream or used very often. So when these phrases are searched, the non-mainstream or extremists sites show up. It is a problem that is very hard to get around because there is no way to stop it besides completely restricting some words or phrases which goes against what Google wants.

In general, Google is a very effective search engine that helps users find the most reliable sources to their search. It also has a feature that allow user to update news with reliable sources. Google has been an effective tools for users to find their answers for many years and now it also helps people to take in information from reliable sources. With the size of Google right now, this new feature of Google has an important meaning to social and political violence. It allows users to find the right answer as long as they willing to look for it at the right source.

The problem with Google is that it relies more on the publishers reputation than following the search string algorithm. This leads to the users not finding the exact answers that they were looking for. This thing became huge when in 2016 Google put [fake news with false numbers for its top search results about the 2016 Elections](#) saying that Donald Trump won both the popular and electoral votes, which was not true.

Criticism of Google

The first criticism that users have about Google is [click fraud](#). Click fraud occurs when Web site publishers click on ads on their site to boost their revenue or when companies click on rivals' ads to eat away at their advertising budgets. Invalid clicks, for which Google does not charge advertisers, include inadvertent double clicks on an ad. Since Google cannot provide data about click fraud, advertisers have to use third party companies to fight against click fraud. Industry reports say fraudulent clicks range from 14 percent to 20 percent of total clicks. Google has introduced a new system is called Adwords and customers will be able to see data on invalid clicks on a daily basis.

The second major criticism of Google is [user privacy](#). On March 1st, 2012, Google began to allow sharing data across a wide variety of services. The policy was widely criticized for creating an environment that discourages Internet-innovation by making Internet users more fearful and wary about what they put online. Privacy International has raised concerns because of Google having a centrally-located widely popular data warehouse of millions of Internet users' searches. At one point, Google could have been forced to hand over all such information to the U.S. government. In 2007, in its [Consultation Report](#), Privacy International ranked Google as "Hostile to Privacy", its lowest rating on their report, making Google the only company in the list to receive that ranking.

In the summer of 2016, Google quietly dropped its ban on including personally-identifiable info in its DoubleClick ad service. The policy was changed to state it "may" combine web-browsing records obtained through DoubleClick with what the company learns from the use of other Google services. While new users were automatically opted-in, existing users were asked if they wanted to opt-in, and it remains possible to opt-out by going to the "Activity controls" in the "My Account" page of a Google account. DoubleClick ads that follow people around on the web may now be customized based on your name and other information Google knows about you. It also means that Google could now, if it wished to, build a portrait of a user by name, based on everything the user writes in their email, every website they visit, and the searches they conduct. Google responded that it doesn't "currently" use Gmail keywords to target web ads.

Beside the two major threats that we mentioned, there are some other potential for data disclosure such as attacking user's cookies, tracking, or Gmail. Because of the size of the company and the size of data that Google has to process, it will be extremely hard for Google to provide users different tools to protect themselves online. If users want to protect their data on a higher level they need to be equipped with products that cover their digital footprints.

Recommended Reading

"[7 Ways to Master the New Google News](#)" by Michael Simon, *PC World*, June 20, 2018.

"[A Deep Look at Google's Biggest-Ever Search Quality Crisis](#)" by Danny Sullivan, *Search Engine Land*, April 3, 2017.

"[Google Has a Striking History of Bias Against Black Girls](#)" by Safiya Noble, *Time*, March 26, 2018.

"[Google Tried to Change China; China May End Up Changing Google](#)" by Farad Majoo, *The New York Times*, August 22, 2018.

"[Google's 'Dirty Secret' Allows Third Party Apps to Read Gmail Messages](#)" by Steven Lerner, *Tech Times*, July 3, 2018.

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4.3: YouTube



YouTube logo as of 2017 via [Wikimedia Commons](#).

Beginning of YouTube

YouTube was created in 2005 and originally was intended to be a [dating website](#). Today YouTube is the biggest video sharing website known and used around the globe. YouTube's [mission](#) is to give everyone a chance to make their voice heard across the world. This mission also includes allowing the content creators to use their freedom of speech and expression actively. To create the most personalized environment for its users, YouTube collects data over time to recommend the most relevant videos for them. YouTube collects data from its users by putting their information into an [algorithm](#) to figure out what is most relevant for users to view next. YouTube was only around for one year before Google decided to buy them. Google created [Google AdSense](#), a program designed to put ads before, during, and after the videos based on the interests of the specific viewer. These advertisements are a significant part in [funding](#) for both YouTube and their content creators, which allows for consistent uploading of a seemingly infinite amount of videos on the site.

YouTube and the Media

YouTube has become a huge [resource](#) for people to access all kinds of content, including the news. The site has verified channels that a user can turn to get their news or see coverage of news that was seen on a different platform. This way of having access to video or news coverage from not only yesterday, or a week ago, but even multiple years ago, provides the user with access to information possibly not found elsewhere. The site also has a "[Trending](#)" page with videos that YouTube determines as the videos that are garnering views at the fastest rate. The videos on this page tend to gather the most attention because they are easily accessible. YouTube, while still trying to allow users to freely express themselves, moderates videos that are posted as well as comments on videos. The company has a '[Community Guidelines](#)' page that discusses what kind of videos should not be uploaded. These guidelines cover things such as [hateful content](#), nudity or sexual content, violent or graphic content, threats, privacy, etc. Despite having these guidelines, the company relies heavily on users to report or flag content that they feel is not appropriate.

YouTube: A Valid Source?

There are a few concerns and critiques of YouTube that should be addressed. One main concern of YouTube is that the [anonymity](#) on the site can make it easier for people to blindly hate or bully someone while keeping their real identity a secret. Another issue is that the recommendations provided by the algorithm tend to push viewers toward more extreme content. This can [amplify extremist political material](#) and has led to [children's programming that is grotesque and disturbing](#).

A common [critique](#) when it comes to YouTube is the copyright claims for certain videos, clips, and songs used in videos that restrict the amount of money YouTubers make. YouTube has made it so these companies or corporations can easily claim copyright and this can cause certain videos to be removed or blocked. The YouTuber may even have to pay the corporation or company for copyright claims when the YouTuber didn't really do anything wrong. One way in which YouTube could solve this [major issue](#) would be to make it so that YouTube requires proof that copyright infringement is actually happening before a video gets shut down or blocked.

Recommended Reading

"[The Battle Between YouTube and the Mainstream Media](#)" by Joe Bish, *Vice*, May 3, 2017.

"[YouTube's Copyright Strikes Have Become a Tool for Extortion](#)" by Shoshana Wodinsky, *The Verge*, Feb. 11, 2019.

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4.4: Snapchat



Snapchat logo via [Wikimedia Commons](#).

If you have a smartphone you have probably heard of the app Snapchat: it's an app that [allows you to connect](#) and share images with your friends. The application allows you to send pictures, text messages, and videos that disappear after being opened. At least, that is how the app started. Snapchat has since grown to include games, public "stories," and news headlines. The Snapchat app has around [158 million users daily](#) with around 85% of those users being between the age of 18 and 35. Snapchat (or Snap Inc.) is a publicly traded company on the [New York Stock Exchange](#), and is still ran by the [original founders](#) Evan Spiegel and Bobby Murphy. Facebook in the past has made offers to buy out the company, but as of yet, Snapchat has remained independent. The status of being independently owned and not associated with other large corporations has definitely shaped the platform in terms of what news they show and how Snapchat makes revenue.

Components of Snapchat

Chat: Friends who have each others' usernames are able to send text messages that disappear once exited. The chat may also be used to respond directly to a friend's image or video post. Users can choose to "save" messages if they wish.

Lenses: Lenses allow users to supplement their images with various filters and effects, including sponsored content for different companies and organizations.

Product identification: By pressing on one's screen for a few seconds, one can identify songs with Shazam or find products on Amazon that most closely resemble the product selected within the frame.

Snapchat's Influence on the News

Over the years Snapchat has accumulated more platforms within the app that allowed for the expansion of public content. From more [notable sources](#) like *The New York Times*, *National Geographic*, and *The Wall Street Journal*, to more blog-like stories such as *SEVENTEEN* and *Cosmo*, Snapchat now contains a wide variety of "story" content. With access to these stories, Snapchat users get a snippet of what is happening in the other parts of the world with celebrities, politics, and "shocking" events in the past 24 hours. Because Snapchat is able to freely publicize user material, news stories sometimes include images and videos from other users present at the scene of the story. Because these stories don't require much time or reading, a user can find out about a current event within seconds before deciding if they want to look further into or continue on to other headlines. These news stories are broken up by video advertisements, and users can choose to subscribe to news platforms. Once subscribed, [Snapchat's algorithm](#) presents the user with other stories that may interest them.

As stated by [The Center for Digital Ethics and Policy](#), Snapchat presents itself as a camera app, not a media platform, and similar to Facebook, Snapchat does not feel responsible for the content that is placed on the platform. The news stories that are posted on the app generally originate in live pictures and videos posted by users, due to the nature of the app. With crowd sourcing information, it is extremely difficult to monitor the content and to fact check the events. In regards to the Discovery section of Snapchat, which presents users with news stories from news sources, only groups that are partnered with Snapchat are allowed to post. Due to this, Snapchat can pick and choose which sources they would like to be partnered with, and are able to cancel partnerships if Snapchat feels the information is not what they want. This can both be good and bad, on one hand Snapchat can eliminate false news from the platform, but on the other hand Snapchat can censor sources that they do not agree with.

Snapchat Trends

Snapchat's [stated mission](#) is "At Snap, we believe that reinventing the camera represents our greatest opportunity to improve the way people live and communicate. We contribute to human progress by empowering people to express themselves, live in the moment, learn about the world, and have fun together." This social media platform has pushed the boundaries of how people communicate, especially for teenagers. The current state of Snapchat is very different from what it was in its inception, and the popularity of the platform is too. Snapchat is reported to be the highest activity for social media at 35% among teens, according to [Pew Research Center](#).

Snapchat's arguably most recognizable trend is that the things you send or post "disappear", except that is not necessarily the case. Users have the capabilities on their devices to "screenshot" or "screen record" pictures and videos they are sent personally, as well as the content posted on their friends' stories (public posts that all of the users' friends can view). Snapchat was the first to implement stories, and this trend has spread and been [copied by the other giant social media platforms](#) like Instagram, Facebook, and now Youtube as well.

According to [Amnesty International](#), Snapchat has not done enough to ensure privacy among its users, and they do not put enough effort into educating their users about the dangers possible on the site. One of the bigger issues is that Snapchat holds users' pictures and videos [for up to 30 days on a company server](#), leaving that data susceptible to hackers. However, the newest "trend" on Snapchat is its relatively new advertising strategy that makes it possible for smaller and bigger brands alike to put ads through Snapchat, and this is done through Snapchat [sending user data to companies](#) so they can target their respective audiences. Pushing the boundary further, Snapchat has a [new partnership with Amazon](#) for product identification that involves users being able to scan items or barcodes with their camera to then be provided with a list of options to buy from Amazon. Convenient? Sure. Good for privacy? We will just have to wait and find out for ourselves.

Loopholes and Community Concerns

- Ability to circumvent age restrictions: Snapchat, like most social media sites requires users to be at least 13 years old. While this is true, people simply lie.
- Terms of service say you can't do anything illegal: Because there isn't anyone going through and checking every message sent to look for illegal activity, it is very easy for people to send messages involving, for example, illegal substances.
- CAN regulate users by reviewing any and all materials posted, but regulation is very lax.
- Snap Inc., is not held liable for any illegal and/or harmful content posted; more concerned about copyright infringement.
- Product identification: partnering with Amazon to identify and market Amazon products: the camera can identify products and suggest similar products for the user to buy.
- Access to geolocations of users unless turned off in settings: Snapchat can see where you are
- Access to all contacts and photos on user devices.
- May mimic your face, voice, or other traits for the purposes of advertising without compensation.

What Should Snapchat do?

While many other social media sites struggle with fake news media, Snapchat remains relatively free of misleading news. According to [Bloomberg Businessweek](#), Snapchat is one of few social media sites that does not have an issue with fake news. As was stated in previous sections, Snapchat only posts content from sources who they have a partnership with. Due to Snapchat picking and choosing who to partner with, they have been able to be clear of fake news and only partner with reputable news sources. Their content chief has also said "If an individual story gets hundreds of thousands of views, a team of our editors looks at it." If the story is checked and found to be true, it is then posted by Snapchat to the "Our Stories" section on Snapchat, which can function as a type of news. Snapchat has also already been actively fighting back against fake news. The company has reportedly been helping to [fund research](#) in creating an algorithm to detect fake news, this way they can assist other platforms in riding the internet of the problem.

One method of regulation that Snapchat has is community regulation. Individual users can [report other users](#) and content by their discretion. This can allow for Snapchat to eliminate illegal activities, and to eliminate user abuse. Another option for closing loopholes could be to require verification of user identity. This will hold people more accountable and make sure that users are the appropriate age to be using the application. Snapchat already allows an optional [two-factor identification](#) for users, requiring new accounts to verify with a mobile phone number. However there are other ways to go about verifying users, for instance they could use [Twitter's](#) model of verification. This can also help to reduce the amount of fake bot accounts on the platform. On the other side, requiring verification could have negative impacts for people that run multiple accounts. For instance, a person who has an

account for personal use and an account to use as a public figure. Verification can also lead to the false assumption that because a person is verified, the company supports them, when in reality it just means that the person is who they say they are.

Now we will leave it to you, the reader, do you think that Snapchat is doing enough? What would you like to see change?

Recommended Reading

“Facebook is Being Eclipsed by its Youthful Rival Snapchat” by Mark Sweney, *The Guardian*, Aug. 27, 2018.

“How Snapchat is Shaping Social Media” by Katie Benner, *The New York Times*, Nov. 30, 2016.

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4.5: 8chan



8chan logo via [Wikimedia Commons](#).

8chan (also known as infinitychan or infinitechan) originated in October 22, 2013 as a response to the supposed “authoritarian” development of the imageboard 4chan according to its developer [Frederick Brennan](#), otherwise known by his online pseudonym “Hotwheels”. 8chan is an imageboard designed to allow for the unabridged free speech of its anonymous users. It has a small user base when compared to social media giants like Facebook, but ranks [3776th](#) in global user visits. The site requires no registration for its use, and [claims to hold no information](#) on its users (a claim doubted by some users), with users being identified only by IP address and a randomly generated numeric code. It is only moderated by the individual board’s owner, allowing difficulty in holding individual rule-breakers accountable outside of removing their rule-breaking posts & banning their IP addresses.

There is one guiding rule for the entirety of the site: “[Do not post, request, or link to any content that is illegal in the United States of America and do not create boards with the purpose of posting or spreading such content.](#)” The site accepts [advertisement](#), allowing for [threads’ placement at the top of board](#) pages with payment. Despite these routes, the site is bankrolled by the owner of the site, Jim Watkins. [Watkins got his start](#) in the online pornography business in the early days of the internet, and owns NT Technology, a server hosting business which he used to repossess the domain of 2chan. The website has yet to make profit, instead surviving due to Watkins’ patronage, for better or worse. 8chan has had some of its largest struggles with policing its own community; many cases of legal offenses and even some terroristic events have occurred.

Media Spotlight

While 8chan itself is far from a ‘news site’ in any classic definition of the phrase, it certainly does its fair share to earn itself a name in the news. Its continual gain in attraction to nefarious counter-culture groups like the Alt-right, the site even hosts a board which provides a space for pedophiles to create dialogue, some users even sharing links to child pornography images or sites. The track record is not good, and appears as though the site is making no genuine efforts to correct the actions that have been made clear to them. Some would argue, including Brennan himself, that ‘[it is simply the cost of free speech...](#)’. But the crackdowns below are not the first, nor the last of 8chan’s problems with the law, nor are they exhaustive at this point.

/Baphomet/ & Swatting: An escalation of Gamergate

Baphomet, the supposed idol of the Knights of Templar turned symbol of the Church of Satan, was co-opted by 8chan users in 2015 on the tail end of the gamergate scandal. The group was a hub of people who desired to ‘[SWAT](#)’ on those that the community of the board deemed threatening/critical of the goals of gamergate: the increase in numbers of female video game developers and producers. Eventually, much of the thread was expunged from 8chan, but only after a user of the board attempted to ‘[doxx](#)’ [Judge Katherine Forrest](#), who preceded over the influential [Silk Road](#) case.

8chan Removed From Google Search Results Over Reports of Child Abuse

Later in the same year as the SWATing incident, 8chan was [removed from the search results of Google’s search engine](#) during an investigation into allegations of child abuse, ranging from images of children that were just on the close side of the law to explicitly sexual images of children and the discussion of pedophile’s lust for children, including their tips and tricks for dealing with their sexual appetites, and even discussions of what they felt was their ‘persecution’.

Louisiana State Police and Alleged Antifa Membership Roster

[The Louisiana state P.D. is being sued](#) over its refusal to allow the public release of a supposed [Antifa](#) roster which some argue has been harvested from the boards of 8chan. Knowing the reputation of this site concerning false sources, pranks, and harassment, the factual validity of the document is questionable, at best. This document has been [circulated](#) throughout the Louisiana Police Dept. and appears to be part of an active investigation.

Shooter's Manifestos Posted to 8chan

In April of 2019, [two separate terrorists posted manifestos to 8chan](#) before engaging in violent actions that left over 50 dead, collectively. Both of these actions were politically motivated, and inspired, at least in part, by the extremity of 8chan's white nationalist population. In New Zealand, the shooter's anti-Muslim bigotry inspired him to open fire on two separate religious establishments, with catastrophic results. Shortly afterward, another gunman mimicked the New Zealand terrorist, posting his own manifesto in which he praised the New Zealand shooter. He then traveled to a synagogue to act out his own attack on one of Powey, California's Jewish communities.

8chan's Culture

Having been popularized during an exodus of extremist users from 4chan and other message board sites, 8chan has only one intention: to be a haven of unfettered free speech rights. As mentioned in the introduction, there is only one universal rule for using the site, and that is to avoid posting/linking services and content that is illegal in the United States. This rudimentary set of guidelines is still too stringent for the admins of 8chan, and as a result they only seem to respond to their own rules when violations of U.S. laws are waved before their faces or when they are threatened with legal action. All marginalized groups are fair game on this website, which is resistant to political correctness, anti-feminist, and home to [radical voices](#) from many ideologies.

I don't have a problem with white supremacists talking on 8chan.

— [Jim Watkins](#), 8chan owner

8chan also allows for complete anonymity for its users, requiring no registration, log in, or verification of identity. Users are instead identified merely by a number serial which is random, resulting in a [loss of personal identification](#) and accountability. The 8chan administration can view what IP address that users are browsing with, and ban them from the site, but users are otherwise protected from punishment. While in line with the goal of the site, these facts make it no easy task to hold users accountable, and emboldens them to behave in ways which they would not be able to on other, more moderated platforms.

"Free speech" in the case of 8chan, has lead to a prevalence of conspiracy theories due to a complete lack of moderation. From claims that [Hillary Clinton ran a child sex trafficking ring from the basement of a pizza parlour](#), to assertions that there is a [deep-state government](#) controlling the heads of state (specifically those opposed to the sitting president), many subversive opinions and theories gain traction on this site, and some even seep into the pores of more credible sources. This muddling of people's worldview is part and parcel of the overall 'Troll' mentality of the user base, which consistently uses disinformation campaigns, exploitation of technology, and online mob-tactics to spread its ideology.

A quick key to imageboard vernacular

- fullchan: 8chan
- halfchan: 4chan
- normal*f*g or normaln*****: normal person, especially one who follows/subscribes to mainstream beliefs and popular culture
- Xf*f*g: person overly obsessed with X thing
- >>>/out/ or >>>/reddit/ : used in a reply when a person does not put enough effort into their post. the Reddit reference comes from the popular idea on 8chan that Reddit users come to 8chan to find memes and flood the board with low-quality, low-effort posts
- boomer: pretty much anyone over the age of 40; derogatory for someone who is out of touch with the ongoings of the world
- zoomer: a person in Generation Z; derogatory for a young person interested or obsessed with mainstream culture
- doomer: a depressed person who has given up on the world or otherwise believes the world is doomed, usually because of "degeneracy". mostly bunkers in the /doomer/ board on 8chan
- fed: anyone who advocates for governmental control over imageboards and other parts of the internet, or is believed to be a member of law enforcement attempting data collection on the users of the site
- tripf*f*g: a person who uses the tripcode system in order to have a persistent username on the site. Tripcodes are cryptographically generated from a password, which is entered every time one makes a post or reply on the site. derogatory as "tripf*f*gging", the act of using a tripcode to identify oneself across posts, goes against the board culture of anonymity
- avatarf*f*gging: including an image of the same character or person across all of one's posts, much like one would have an avatar or profile picture on a traditional social media site
- "glow-in-the-dark n***** from the CIA": a person who advocates for governmental surveillance and backdoored online services, particularly on /tech/ where the prevailing board culture values libre software, security, and privacy. comes from a

popular verbal tic of Terry Davis, a programmer revered by imageboards for his frequent racist screeds and singlehandedly creating the computer operating system TempleOS because he believed God told him to

- lolcow: a person who can be easily goaded into doing embarrassing things on the internet for trolls' amusement

8chan Iconography and Dog-Whistles

A dog-whistle in a political sense is coded language employed in a way so that the general public cannot fully understand the true meaning that the ingroup understands it. Dog whistles are often disguised as completely mundane and innocuous language as to allow those in the ingroup to completely disavow the dog whistle's true meaning and say that they were using the normal usage of it. Both 4 and 8 chan have created multiple dog-whistles and have worked them into their existing iconography.

- [Pepe](#)
 - Probably the oldest and best-known image coming from 4 and 8 Chan. The character originated from the comic Boy's Club written by Matt Furie but quickly was co-opted by the Chans and became a mascot of sorts. But as they moved further towards extremism and bigotry so did Pepe leading to the [Anti-Defamation League classifying it as a hate symbol](#).
- [NPC](#)
 - The NPC meme was created to mock progressives and pretty much everyone else left of center by comparing them to NPCs (non-player characters) from video games. A video game NPC is nothing but a machine programmed to repeat the same lines over and over. Members of 4 and 8 Chan compare their political adversaries to them in order to dehumanize them, which could potentially lead to violence.
- [Kekistan](#)
 - A fake nation created in 4chan around 2017 as a home for the members of site. It became a symbol for /pol/, and as time went on the flag started to show up at right wing rallies such as the ["Unite the Right Rally" where Heather Heyer was killed](#). The flag itself looks like an altered nazi flag with the swastikas replaced with the word "Kek" and the flag itself recolored to green, doubtlessly referencing Pepe.
- [The "Ok Hand"](#)
 - One of the older dog whistles but one that is still being used today. It was [originally created](#) to make people who called them out on it look absurd. The sign means white power, the three fingers are the W and the thumb and the pointer finger along with the wrist being the P. The members of 4chan showed an image of Mel Gibson (who famously made multiple anti-Semitic remarks) making the sign alongside an image explaining it to give the fake dog whistle credibility. As time has passed, the hand sign has developed from a meme into a disparaging symbol, as shown with the Christchurch shooter making it during his shooting [and in court](#).
- Any common noun (who, they, etc.) surrounded with three sets of parentheses or asterisks
 - This is a way for them to discuss their Jewish deep state conspiracy without being too overt. Many members on the Chans believe that there is a vast Jewish conspiracy that has control of the world governments and mainstream media. Replace the noun in the parenthesis or asterisks with "The Jews."

What Can Be Done?

To ban or not to ban, that is the question, and around that question there is much debate. Hate groups, like white nationalist organizations and anti-gender-equality groups, often espouse the message that they are woefully oppressed and suppressed by the government and liberals, hence their migration to platforms like 8chan to escape accountability. In a climate such as this, [marginalizing them further may lead to deeper convictions](#). Unfortunately, as the administrative leaders of 8chan are reluctant to acknowledge their role in the real-life consequences of their cyber laissez-faire, there are not many courses that this website will take. This problem is exacerbated further by the fact that while the website has servers in the United States, those in control of the site itself reside outside the legal bounds of the U.S. system.

Would government action restricting content on the site violate the First Amendment? A great deal of the population would refer to the website as the darkest place on the internet, which some would use to argue for the censorship of its content. The First Amendment states "Congress shall make no law respecting an establishment of religion, or prohibiting the free exercise thereof; or abridging the freedom of speech, or of the press; or the right of the people peaceably to assemble, and to petition the Government for a redress of grievances." At the time of its creation, the First Amendment was devised to protect the individual from having their civil liberties infringed upon by a tyrannical government. Acts of violence encouraged by a space that does not have an underlying ethical conformity besides freely speaking like this site poses a challenge: is this speech legally protected? Cases such

as of [Miller v. California](#) (1973) which proposed a test for whether speech is obscene and therefore not protected and [Chaplinsky v. New Hampshire](#) (1942), concerning speech that provokes violence, suggest some of the speech expressed on 8chan is not necessarily protected under the First Amendment. However, the site's administrators live abroad and might claim immunity is provided by [Section 230](#) of the Telecommunications Act of 1996.

Commercial constraints are not likely to moderate 8chan. This is not a normal case of social media management, and therefore will be near impervious to economic constraints, seeing as it already appears as though the site doesn't earn enough money itself to stay in the dark. Social pressure also will not alleviate this problem, as 8channers are the type to feed off of detraction. Hopefully, as this site [grows](#) in its influence and popularity, its administration will be forced to seek new employees, some of whom may see this problem for what it is, not as some bastion of free speech, but a host for those who are willing to weaponize it to prove a point.

Some countries, like New Zealand, that have seen extreme violence as a result of the radicalization of the site's users are blocking accessibility to the site, taking the only recourse left to them by a website that continually pushes the envelope. Unfortunately, users in these countries may be empowered by this silencing of their counter culture, but the world may have to cross each bridge as we get to them in cases like these.

Recommended Reading and Viewing

“[Meet the Man Keeping 8chan, The World’s Most Vile Website, Alive](#)” by Ethan Chiel, *Splinter*, April 19, 2016.

[The Other America ‘Frederick Brennan’](#) *Al Jazeera America*, n.d.

“[The Cops Want to Know What’s Happening on 8Chan](#)” by Ali Breland, *Mother Jones*, April 5, 2019.

“[Why Banning the Toxic, Racist 8chan Message Board Could Backfire](#)” by Ali Breland, *Mother Jones*, May 1, 2019.

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4.6: Twitter



photo courtesy of [World's Direction](#) (public domain)

[Twitter](#), founded in 2006, was initially designed as a “microblogging” platform for posting short public messages that would be aggregated in reverse chronological order. Now a publicly-traded company, it made its initial public offering (IPO) in 2013, making Jack Dorsey, one of its founders and its current CEO, an instant billionaire. At the time of the IPO, Twitter operated at a loss and did not [post a profit until the first quarter of 2018](#). Nearly all of its revenue is from advertising but some of it comes from licensing the use of the data it gathers from users to third parties. Its share of the digital advertising market falls well behind Google, Facebook, and Amazon and [has a relatively small user base](#) of 126 million daily active users. The tension between efforts to grow the user base and [removing bots](#) and [abusive accounts](#) that damage the brand has been a constant challenge for its business model.

How Twitter Influences the News

In spite of the fact it has far fewer users than Facebook or Snapchat, Twitter has [a strong influence on news sharing](#) because the platform design favors immediacy and provides a quick snapshot of trends. For example, the killing of Mike Brown in Ferguson, MO, and subsequent protests were barely visible on Facebook [but dominated Twitter](#) before journalists arrived to cover the story. Journalists rely on Twitter as a crowdsourcing platform – to get a sense of what is capturing public attention – as well as a place to promote and share new stories. An [April 2019 survey](#) from Pew Research suggests Twitter users in the United States are not demographically representative, but tend to skew left and young. Users of the platform in other countries may have a different profile.

Public figures have also found Twitter a platform for promoting ideas and getting reactions in real time. Unlike Facebook, Twitter does not rely on algorithms tied to your personal information to tailor what you see in your feed (though it uses algorithms to screen out some illegal or abusive material). What news you see primarily depends on who you follow and what they post or retweet in real time. Changes made in the platform have in subtle ways changed how people interact on Twitter. For example, [one preliminary study showed](#) allowing users to comment on a tweet by “tweet quoting” rather than simply replying appears to have somewhat improved the civility of political discourse and extended the conversation to a more politically diverse group of users. [Further changes are in the works](#).

The [use of Twitter by President Trump](#) has bolstered the political influence of the platform far beyond its user base. It has also caused significant controversy. Users [won a lawsuit](#) against the president for blocking their accounts. (When public officials use social media, they are acting as agents of the government in a public forum. “The viewpoint-based exclusion of the individual plaintiffs from that designated public forum is proscribed by the First Amendment” according to the court’s decision, which is under appeal.) President Trump has, in other ways, benefitted by using Twitter as a public megaphone, frequently bypassing normal White House channels to announce policies or personnel decisions.

Twitter has also benefited from his frequent use. One analyst [predicted the company would lose \\$2 billion](#) if the president stopped using the platform, amounting to 20 percent of the company’s market capitalization. Though many users have reported tweets posted by the president for violating the platform’s rules, his account has not been suspended or banned. In 2018 Twitter responded to complaints (without naming Trump) by [announcing](#) public figures have a special “newsworthy” status which exempts them from enforcement imposed on less prominent users, basically saying rules can be broken if you are important enough.

Twitter’s Culture(s)

The company’s [current values statement](#) is “We believe in free expression and think every voice has the power to impact the world.” Though Twitter’s [policies](#) ban threats of violence, doxxing, and “hateful conduct,” it has been [markedly reluctant to enforce its policies](#). Amnesty International [released a report in 2018](#) documenting how toxic the platform is for women, who are often threatened with violence for expressing themselves. Women of color in particular receive the worst abuse. Twitter CEO Jack Dorsey responded, saying “We love instant, public, global messaging and conversation. It’s what Twitter is and it’s why we’re here. But we didn’t fully predict or understand the real-world negative consequences.” In spite of multiple changes to its terms of use, abuse persists. In April, 2019 the company [announced it was having some success](#) removing abusive content using an algorithm rather than responding only to flagged content.

Twitter does not have a “real names” policy; users can create multiple accounts and do not have to disclose information about themselves beyond an email address. In its terms of service, Twitter forbids impersonating others, but allows parody and fan accounts. Users are able to choose whether to share location or other information and whether to have ads targeted to them or not. The data Twitter collects is used to build profiles for advertisers and is shared with some third parties; this [appears to be a growing part of its business](#).

Twitter was the first social media company to introduce a verification process to enable some users to provide additional proof of identity and earn a “blue check” by their handle. Though some people mistake that as a marker of quality or authority, it simply means the company ascertained the person behind the account was real and had gained enough notoriety to be recognized with a check mark. Twitter was criticized for giving white supremacists who organized the Unite the Right rally verified accounts, [removing them](#) only as the rally approached. In 2018 the verification program was suspended so the company could redesign the program. The application process remains unavailable.

Automated accounts (bots) have presented a problem for the platform. The company acknowledged the wide use of bots and [deleted tens of millions of suspect accounts](#) in 2018, though [recent research](#) suggests real accounts supporting Trump in an organized mobilization may have been more influential than bots in the 2016 presidential election. That said, bots on Twitter continue to be a concern for 2019 elections in [Sweden](#), [Canada](#), [Israel](#), [India](#), and elsewhere.



Visualization of Twitter bots during the 2019 Israeli election created by Zignal courtesy of TED (cited in recommended reading). The white dots are accounts held by read people; pink and dark pink are bots.

Though Twitter is known for broadcasting opinions, it has also become a place where communities of interest gather and share information. Academics use it to share their research and keep in touch with others in their disciplines ([#Twitterstorians](#) and [#PhDchat](#) are examples) or tweet during academic conferences. They also make use of [Twitter's application program interface \(API\)](#) for analyzing public sentiment. “[Black Twitter](#)” became a phrase to describe the high percentage of African Americans (and black people elsewhere) using the platform for communication and [activism](#). Twitter has also become a favored platform for [white supremacists](#) in part because it allows multiple account creation and anonymity, enforces its policies inconsistently, and is reluctant to take action against prominent extremists.

What Twitter Should Do

All social platforms that depend on data-gathering and advertising as a business model face a conundrum: algorithmic mechanisms that encourage engagement can also encourage extremism and drive away users who encounter hate speech and abuse. Publicly-traded companies may be reluctant to take action that could depress earnings, but are also at risk if not taking action damages their brand or results in lawsuits or government sanction. In the [public annual report](#) to shareholders required by the Securities and Exchange Commission, Twitter identifies numerous risks faced by the company. Their 2018 [transparency report](#) report states the company over 200 million accounts were reported for “spam or abuse” in six months of 2018. Roughly a quarter million accounts were sanctioned for “abuse” and around 43,000 for making violent threats. The company also [conducted a review](#) of mistakes made during the 2016 election and outlined its efforts to combat malicious activity during the midterm election of 2018. Yet [researchers have identified](#) Twitter’s problematic delay in dealing with problems that can be identified quickly. Likewise, the findings of the Amnesty International report suggest the company does not take threats and abuse seriously enough.

The confluence of political influence and hate speech can be illustrated by President Trump’s [endorsing a misleading video](#) about Minnesota’s US Representative Ilhan Omar by retweeting it and adding a misleading comment, inflaming an already dangerous situation for the legislator who had been [targeted with death threats on Twitter](#). A cybersecurity expert [was able to find accounts aiming violence at the lawmaker](#) within a couple of hours. He argues the platform could take greater responsibility by monitoring obvious threats and taking quick action. This will require a combination of algorithmic monitoring (which has shown some success) and human intervention, which should be made a priority. Hiring social scientists trained in anthropology, psychology, and communication studies could complement research and development efforts. There should also be some process for quarantining and saving records of account action that is under investigation by law enforcement, journalists, or researchers.

Additionally, like all advertising-funded platforms, laws must be passed and regulations enforced that make it possible to clearly label the source of funding for campaign advertisements and to ensure compliance with all campaign finance laws in countries where Twitter operates. Further, as licensing personal data becomes an increasingly important revenue stream, the company should prepare to comply with new privacy legislation such as the [General Data Protection Regulation \(GDPR\)](#) passed in the European Union and, as cyber risks proliferate, take measures to prevent [breaches](#) and hacks.

Finally, the company appears to have a [dysfunctional management culture](#) that makes it difficult to make hard decisions or implement improvements. Given the platform’s influence on the flow of information, particularly political news, it should make efforts to build a stronger, more stable and inclusive leadership structure.

Recommended Reading and Viewing

“[The Black Feminists Who Saw the Alt-Right Coming](#)” by Rachelle Hampton, *Slate*, April 2019.

[How Twitter Needs to Change](#) (Interview with Jack Dorsey) TED, April 2019.

[Twitter and Teargas: The Power and Fragility of Networked Protest](#) by Zeynep Tufekci (Yale, 2017).

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